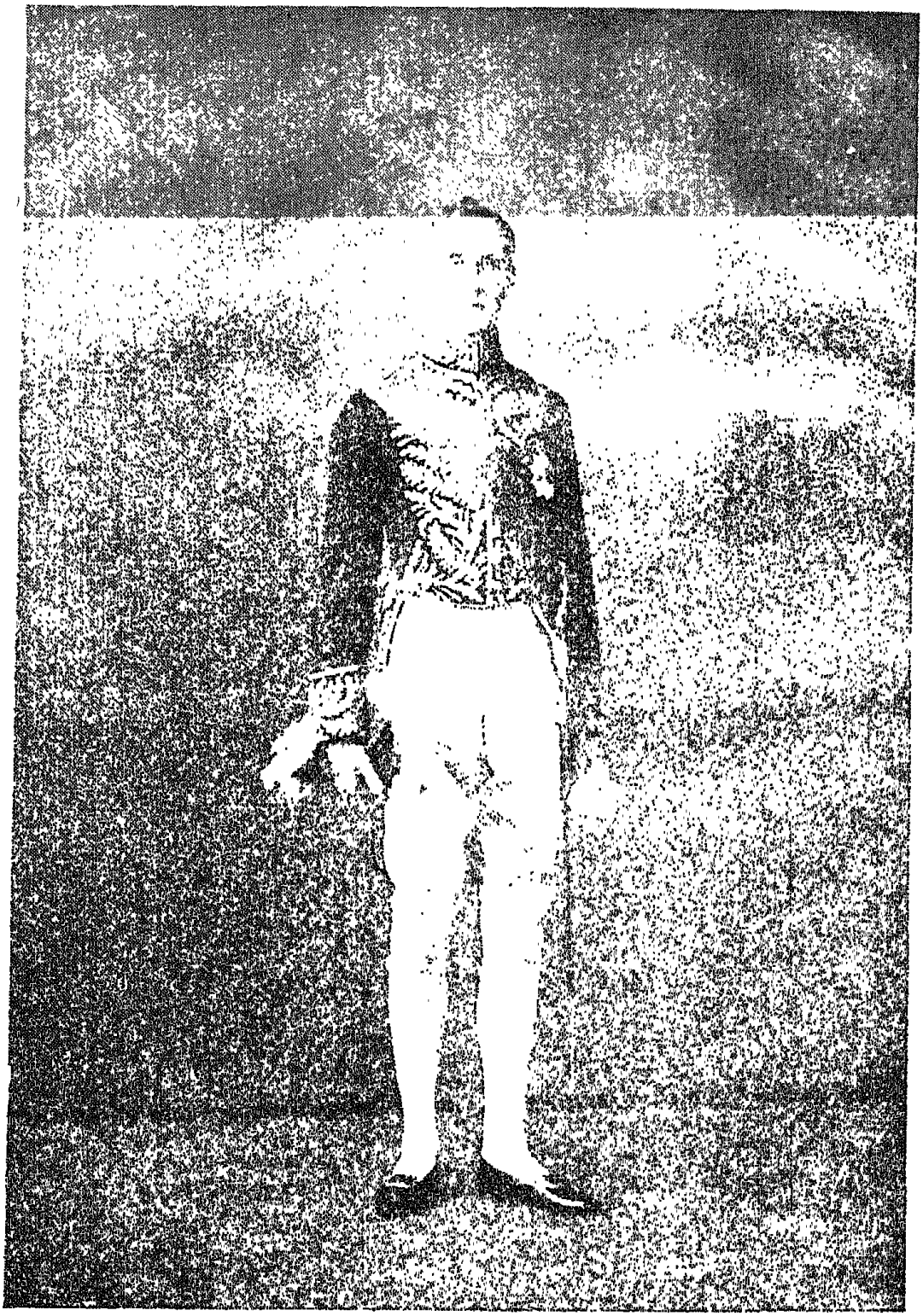


HER EXCELLENCY THE COUNTESS OF LYTTON.



His Excellency the Earl of Lytton, Governor of Bengal.

Calcutta and Environs.

AN ILLUSTRATED HISTORICAL GUIDE TO PLACES OF INTEREST AND TO THOSE SUITABLE FOR EXCURSIONS IN AND AROUND CALCUTTA

BY

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SECOND EDITION.

FOREWORD

In the following pages an attempt has been made to put before the new-comer and the tourist a few simple descriptive notes to direct him to the prominent places of interest in the city of Calcutta and its environs. Whenever possible brief historical notes have been added to show the association of the present day buildings and localities with Old Calcutta.

At the beginning of the book a short history of the origin and development of Calcutta with the rise of British Power in India has been given. An account of its physical geography, climate, drainage and water-supply has also been added in the hope that these may prove interesting as an example of what scientific town planning and sanitation can achieve against dirt and disease.

To facilitate a tour of inspection with the minimum expenditure of time and money an index has been prepared in which the different localities and principal streets in the town and suburbs have been classified alphabetically and the names of places of interest likely to be visited in each have been grouped together.

Excursions by means of railway train service and motor cars as well as those by means of ferry steamers plying up and down the river have been suggested to various suitable places. In this way several localities with old and historic associations between Howrah Station and Bandel Junction on the E. I. Railway and Sealdah Station and Barrackpore on the E. B. Railway can be conveniently visited.

Miscellaneous information concerning places of amusement and recreation, such as cinemas, theatres and clubs has been given as an appendix.

The list of principal banking agencies, foreign consulates and hospitals may also prove useful to the tourist and the new-comer. With the same object an up-to-date map of Calcutta has also been appended.

I take this opportunity of expressing my indebtedness to the Hon'ble Mr. H. E. A. Cotton, C.I.E., President, Bengal Legislative Council, for the help I have received from his comprehensive book, "Calcutta Old and New," and for his kindly writing the Introduction to this edition.

I must also thank Professor Rushbrook-Williams, C.B.E., Director of Central Bureau of Information to the Government of India, who as official historian attached to H. R. H. the Prince of Wales's tour in India and Burmah, kindly brought my humble brochure to the notice of His Royal Highness during his visit to Calcutta in 1922.

I am obliged to Mr. Lal Chand, Proprietor of the firm of Messrs. Lal Chand and Sons, Calcutta, for giving me special facilities of work in his Printing Department.

This book was originally written to serve as a "GUIDE" for visitors to Calcutta during the eighth session of the Indian Science Congress in 1921. It has now been revised and brought up to date, but owing to pressure of professional and other duties the matter had to be rushed through the press and I crave the indulgence of the reader for the shortcomings that may be noticed.

HASSAN SUHRAWARDY.

CALCUTTA :
November 1923.

INTRODUCTION.

"There is always room for a guide to Calcutta." Year after year, even month after month, the landmarks of the past are being obliterated. The Improvement Trust is hard at work driving broad thoroughfares in every direction and the builder of mammoth mansions is busy. Very soon hardly a vestige will remain even of the Calcutta which some of us knew twenty or thirty years ago. My friend Dr. Hassan [illegible] doubly qualified for the task which he has undertaken. He is not only inspired with genuine interest in the history of the city in which he has made his home; he is in addition one of those Indians who combines so successfully the best features of the Western education with the immemorial traditions of the East. I accede with pleasure to his request that I shall write a few words by way of introduction to his book; not because he stands in need of any commendation, but because I rejoice to find an Indian following in the footsteps of Dr. Busteed and other English lovers of Calcutta.

The three Presidency towns stand out from among the other cities of British India by reason of the fact that they are the creation of British enterprise and energy. Each has its own distinctive features. The splendid harbour of Bombay which prides itself upon being the first city in India—*urbs prima in Indis*—in point of time only—and the green freshness of Madras—that city of historic renown, and of distances—may be held to constitute their own peculiar charm. But there is something about Calcutta which is altogether lacking in her sister Presidency towns. She cannot claim to be the earliest possession of the English in India; and she has inherited none of the traditions that linger around the audience chambers of the Great Mogul. Delhi with her Imperial memories, Agra with her

majestic monuments and past associations to which our city set among marshes—*urbs inter paludes*—of old Job Charnock can never aspire. But for a century and-a-half she was the central seat of the British Government in India. There is everything in Calcutta to remind her citizens and to impress upon the strangers within her gates that she is not only the second city of the British Empire, as the Prince of Wales described her, but also the first capital of the British Raj in India—Wellesley's stately Government House, the statues of the past Governor-Generals, upon her wide expanse of the emerald-green maidan, the snow-white fabric of the Victoria Memorial Hall, the massive block of Government offices, the long area of thriving shops upon Chowringhee, the rows of warehouses and of jetties and docks, the river with its multitudes of steamships, the hum and bustle of the restless mercantile quarter with its magnificent buildings, the large European colony whose counterpart whether in numbers or influence will be sought in vain at new Delhi or in the other Presidency towns, the palaces of wealthy Indian noblemen, the signs upon every hand of opulence and prosperity and ceaseless activity. The very names of the streets having their own adventure to tell. Imperfections she possesses, but nothing can deprive her of the vague and tantalizing charm with which she vanquishes her critics.

In these pages Major Suhrawardy has assembled very many sources of available information with regard to the past history of Calcutta and has not been afraid to project a glance into the future. Whatever may be in store for Calcutta, we may be sure that she will always prove worthy of the motto which is subscribed below the arms of the city—*Pet ardua stabilis esto.*

H. E. A. COTTON.

CALCUTTA :
28th November, 1923.

CONTENTS.

CHAPTER I.

CALCUTTA : PAGES

Part I.—The History of its Origin and Development 1—14

Part II.—Physical Geography : Climate, Drainage, Water supply, Area, Population, Sickness and Mortality . . . . . 14—20

CHAPTER II.

ARRIVAL IN CALCUTTA, GENERAL INFORMATION—

Howrah Station 21

Howrah Bridge 25

CHAPTER III.

H. E. THE GOVERNOR'S RESIDENCE AND OTHER IMPORTANT STATE BUILDINGS—

Government House 25

Fort William 28

His Majesty's Mint 31

CHAPTER IV.

SOME PROMINENT PUBLIC BUILDINGS AND INSTITUTIONS—

Town Hall 34

High Court 35

Indian Museum 37

Art Gallery 38

Asiatic Society 39

Metcalfe Hall and Imperial Library 40

The Commercial Museum 42

Commercial Library and Reading Room 42

The Corporation Buildings 42

Calcutta Port Trust 44

Calcutta Improvement Trust 44

The Bengal Chamber of Commerce and Royal Exchange 48

PAGES

CHAPTER V.

EDEN GARDENS: THE STRAND AND THE MAIDAN: MEMORIALS AND MONUMENTS—

The Eden Gardens and Strand Road (South) . . 49
The Maidan 53
Ochterlony Monument 56
Curzon Statue 57
Victoria Memorial 59
Race Course 60

CHAPTER VI.

DALHOUSIE SQUARE AND OTHER PLACES OF HISTORIC INTEREST NEAR IT—

Dalhousie Square 61
General Post Office 62
Black Hole 64
Holwell Monument 67
Custom House 69
East Indian Railway House 69
Writers' Buildings 70
Dalhousie Institute 72
The Central Telegraph Office 73
Currency Office 74
Mission Row 74

CHAPTER VII.

SOME OLD AND INTERESTING PLACES OF WORSHIP—

Kalighat 75
Jain Temples 77
Bhot Mandir 79
The Parsee Fire Temple 79
Jewish Synagogue 80
St. Paul's Cathedral 80
St. John's Church 81
Old Mission Church 85
St. Andrew's Church 85
St. James' Church 87
St. Stephen's Church 87
The Greek Church of our Blessed Redeemer . . . 88

PAGES

Cathedral of our Blessed Lady of the Rosary . . 88
The Church of "Our Blessed Lady of Dolours" 89
The Church of our Lady of the Happy Voyage . 90
Mosques 91
Haji Karbalai's Imambara 93

CHAPTER VIII.

THE CALCUTTA UNIVERSITY AND EDUCATIONAL INSTITUTIONS—

The University 94
Calcutta University Institute 99
Medical College of Bengal 99
The School of Tropical Medicine and Institute of Hygiene 103
The Carmichael Medical College, Belgachia . . 103
Campbell Medical School and Hospital 104
The Presidency College 105
Oriental Studies 106
Scottish Churches College 106
St. Xavier's College 107
The Indian Association for the Cultivation of Science 109
Bose Research Institute 110
The Bengal Engineering College, Sibpur and Shalimar 112

CHAPTER IX.

PLACES OF MISCELLANEOUS INTEREST—

Small Cause Court 114
Marble Palace 114
Municipal Market 115
The Station Hospital for British Soldiers . . . 116

CEMETERIES—

Christian: Old and New 116
Hindu Burning Ghat 118
The Crematorium 119
Parsi Tower of Silence 119
Muslim Burial Grounds 120
Jewish Burial Ground 121

PAGES

CHAPTER X.

THE SUBURBS OF CALCUTTA—
Tollygunge 121
Alipore 123
The Zoological Gardens 123
Belvedere House 124
The Agri-Horticultural Gardens 126
Hastings House 127
The Alipur Observatory 129
Kidderpore House 131
Kidderpore Docks 132

CHAPTER XI.

EXCURSIONS ON THE RIVER AND BY TRAIN SERVICES OR MOTOR CARS—
GENERAL INFORMATION 133
Stations down the River—
The Royal Botanical Gardens, Sibpur 134
Matiaburj or Garden Reach 136
Rajabagan 136
Rajgunge 136
Stations up the River—
Cossipore 137
Kutighat 137
Belur Ghat 137
Bally 137
Uttarpara 137
Sibtala 138

PLACES CONVENIENTLY VISITED BY RAILWAY TRAIN OR MOTOR CARS—
On the E. B. Railway—
Dum-Dum 138
Tittagarh 139
Barrackpur 139

SOME GENERAL INFORMATION FOR THE TOURIST . . 140
On the E. I. Railway—
Lillooah 141
Bally 142

PAGES

Uttarpara 142
Rishra 142
Serampore 133
Chandernagore 145
Chinsurah 146
Hooghly Imambara 146
Bandel Portuguese Church 149

Index of localities arranged alphabetically with places of interest in each 151

General information regarding Tram-car, Ticca Gharry, and Taxi Fares 155

APPENDIX.

Cinemas 156
Theatres 156
Principal Clubs 156
Hotels 157
Restaurants 157
Hospitals and Dispensaries 158
Banking Agencies 159
Consulates 160
Police Head-quarters 160
Port and Shipping Office 160
Map of Calcutta . . . . . At the end.

LIST OF ILLUSTRATIONS.

	PAGES
His Excellency The Earl of Lytton Frontispiece	
Howrah Station	22
Howrah Bridge	24
Her Excellency the Countess of Lytton	25
Government House	29
Town Hall	33
High Court	36
Eden Gardens	47
Grand Stand, Race Course	54
Curzon Statue	58
Victoria Memorial	60
General Post Office	63
Black Hole	65
Writers' Buildings	71
View of Old Court House Street	73
Kalighat Temple	76
Jain Temples	78
St. John's Church	82
Tipu Sultan's Mosque	91
H. E. The Earl of Ronaldshay	95
Senate House, Calcutta University	96
Medical College Hospital	101
St. Xavier's College	108
Bengal Engineering College	113
Belvedere	125
Hastings House	128
Great Banyan Tree, Royal Botanical Gardens	135
Hooghly Imambara	147
Map of Calcutta	End.

CHAPTER I.

CALCUTTA.

[PART I.]

The History of its Origin and Development.

WHEN the Europeans first started commercial relations in Bengal, Satgaon and Hooghly were the chief ports. With the decline of Satgaon due to the river shifting its course the port of Hooghly rose to great eminence under the Portuguese and the Dutch merchants, and the river Bhagirathi, the chief branch of the Ganges, came to be called the river Hooghly after this important town on its west bank.

The Hooghly.

The Dutch established a factory at Chinsurah in 1625, and the English factory was completed in 1658, higher up the river on the opposite side at Kassim Bazar near Murshidabad, the then capital of Bengal. The Ganges has always been the great commercial waterway of Bengal and as a consequence of the impetus caused by the diversion of the trade of Satgaon from other channels into its chief offshoot, the Hooghly river, villages sprang up rapidly on either side, inspite of the unhealthiness and the marshy nature of the surrounding country which was thickly covered with forest and jungle, the home of wild beasts and reptiles, and pestilential fevers. Sutanuti, Gobindapur and Kalikhetra was a group of three such little villages and the story of how they served as the nucleus of our great city of Calcutta is most interesting. Job Charnock, the founder of Calcutta, was senior Agent of the East India Company and seems to have deliberately selected the villages as the mid-day halting place of the English merchants on their journey up the river.

The Mid-day Halting Place.

The story of a convenient mid-day halting place must have been invented as a blind for the benefit of the Moghul authorities. The vessels of the European merchants on their way up the river as a matter of fact used to halt at Bator on the opposite bank, near Sibpur in Howrah, and there was no special reason for abandoning it. The chief cause which must have influenced Charnock in selecting this site appears really to have been its commercial and strategic advantages as the future headquarters of British trade and influence in Bengal and not its convenience as a half-way halting place for rest and refreshment.

The English came to Bengal about the middle of the 17th century as traders, but soon became merchant princes and by the time of Job Charnock, had realised that they must protect themselves and their [illegible] by the force of their own right arm. The days of peaceful merchants begging favours at the hands of the Moghul Governor had disappeared and the idea of being on a footing of equality with the effête government of the Nawab had already gained ground and we find that the claim for building a fort and for coining their own money had been boldly put forward.

The Advantages of the Site.

The site selected by Charnock to found a British settlement suitable as the future headquarters of British trade in Bengal was chosen, because the Hooghly river tapped most of the rich tracts of the Gangetic Valley, and the place was situated at the highest point to which the river was navigable by large sea-going vessels, the site had thus a distinct advantage over both Hooghly and Chandarnagar. In addition to this being nearer the sea, it could provide greater facilities for sea-borne trade and for withdrawal into safety in case of a reverse of fortune, a contingency which some years later was actually

availed of after the capture of the town and fort of Calcutta by Nawab Siraj-ud-Dowla. Furthermore there were no refractory and intriguing factions like the Dutch, the Portuguese and the French to contend with, neither were there the *Faujdar* or the military commander of the Nawab and his troops with whom [illegible] to have as little to do as possible so as to avoid the possibilities of friction. The site had also the additional advantage of being near enough the other European settlements to keep the English promptly informed of what was going on there. Provisions too were plentiful and could easily be obtained from the flourishing [illegible] or the weekly market-places in the villages. The villages themselves and the adjacent country to the north, east and south, were owned by Hindus, from whom land could be obtained on easier terms than from the Muhammadans who were more prosperous and the then ruling power. The river itself served as a great barrier against invasions from the west and also provided a most effective means of protection from the guns of the shipping. The place was also difficult of access on the east and north on account of the salt lakes, morasses, rivers and creeks. On the south it was protected by a mud fort near Garden Reach and Raigarh opposite Makwa Tana where the river was narrowest.

(The name Matiabruj is derived from the existence of this mud fort. Matia in Urdu means made of mud and Bruj is an Urdu word derived from Persian and means a tower of a fortress. Garden Reach is still called Matiabruj by Indians. A strong iron chain extended from shore to shore between the fortress of Matiabruj and that of Mawka Tana, and used to be pulled up to serve as a barrier against invasions by marauding parties from the sea-coast.)

The Three Riparian Villages.

A short note about these three riparian villages may not be out of place here. *Sutanuti* was the most prosperous of the three villages on which the modern City of Palaces stands. It was a cotton mart largely visited by European merchants and traders

dealing in cotton bales. The name seems to be derived from Suta (thread) and Luti (Bengali for bundle or a bank). The word Luti is pronounced as Nuti by many Bengalees as a provincialism. It was in the market-place of this thriving cotton mart called Sutanuti Hat that Job Charnock while seated on a divan under a great peepul tree leisurely smoking his hookah in true oriental fashion, evolved his plan of founding a British settlement there. This spot in the market-place was called *Baithak-khana*, the Indian name for a parlour,—literally it means a sitting place. It was the Bengal Club as well as the Chamber of Commerce for the British merchants of that time and served as a *rendezvous* from which they dispersed with goods for their different factories and sallied forth for their itinery into the country, in groups with the double purpose of providing company to each other, and also of protecting themselves from attacks by robbers, wild beasts and snakes. The Baitakkhana was situated near the present terminus station of the Eastern Bengal Railway, known as the Sealdah station. Charnock's peepul tree stood near the junction of Bow Bazar Street and Lower Circular Road. There is a market which survives to the present day and is still known as the Baitakkhana Bazar. There is however no trace of this historical tree. This old landmark was felled in 1820, to make room for the new road (part of Lower Circular Road), then under construction. Although as a result of an appeal Lord Hastings intervened on its behalf, it was too late, for the tree had already been cut down.

(Sealdah in those days was a thinly populated locality and the dense jungle near by was a veritable jackal's den, hence the name Sealdah from a corruption of a Persian word *Sheghaldeh* which means a jackal village. *Sheghal* means a jackal, *Deh* means a village.)

To the south of Sutanuti, on the site on which Fort William is now situated, was the village of *Gobindapur*. It is said that four families of Basaks (weavers) and Setts (money-lenders) cleared the

jungle and erected houses there. They established a *hât* and a shrine to their patron deity "Vishnu" who is also called Gobindji; hence the name Gobindapur. The well-known Seal family of Calcutta were also among the early settlers of this place as were also the present Mullick family of Chorebagan.

To the south of the first two villages, but extending a little more inland, lay another village of less importance commercially but of more interest from the religious point of view of the Hindus.

In a lonely part of this village on the banks of Adi Ganga or the original Ganges (modern Tolly's Nulla), was situated a very old temple dedicated to the dreaded goddess Kali to whom human sacrifices were offered. *Kali-khetra* was the name of the surrounding locality and it is said to have derived its sanctity and its name from the fact that a piece of the toe of Sati, otherwise known as Kali, the wife of Shiva, had dropped on the site of the temple. Kali is also called Bhawani and hence the adjacent village is known as Bhawanipur after her.

Either through superstition or in order to please the local Hindus the European merchants used to propitiate this goddess by large offerings prior to undertaking important enterprises. As the land route,—a solitary pilgrim path extending along the jungle—was unsafe, they approached the temple by the river, alighting at the ghat or landing-stage called Kalighat which meant the landing-stage of the temple of Kali.

It is very probable that ghat was transliterated in English as ghata just as the Europeans write Ram as Rama, Navadwip as Navadwipa. Thus Kali ghat became Kali ghata, and its transition thence to Kali-kata, and Calcutta is easy to follow. Similarly Baliaghat which means a sandy ghat has now become Belia ghatta by the same process. It is also possible that Kali-khetra came to be pronounced as Kali Kheta, Kalikata, and finally Calcutta.

Anyway this village and the area known as Kalikhetra by its growth and expansion eventually absorbed the neighbouring villages of Gobindapur and Sutanuti which were thus forgotten and Calcutta alone remained known, and became world-famous.

Job Charnock.

Job Charnock, the founder of Calcutta, first came to Bengal in 1682, and was employed at Kassim Bazar and also worked at Hooghly, Sutanuti, Uluberia and Hidjli. Charnock was associated with an expedition against the Nawab's men in which he was defeated and had to retreat to Fort St. George in Madras in 1689. He was shortly afterwards superseded by Captain Heath. Charnock remained in Madras till July, and after patching up a reapproachment with the Nawab again sailed for Bengal, being re-appointed as the Senior Agent of the East India Company. On August 24th 1690, Job Charnock [illegible] of Sutanuti at the place now known as the [illegible] Nimtola "burning ghat" and [illegible] Capital of the British Empire in India. The great founder did not survive this event long. On January 10th 1693, Charnock died and was interred in the burial ground on which now stands St. John's Church, the old Cathedral of Calcutta. It was then an open and dreary place surrounded by a ditch and was the haunt of wild boars and jackals. Charnock's marriage was romantic. It is said that during one of his nightly sojourns by the river bank near the British factory at Tiagarh he rescued a beautiful Hindu widow from the flames of the funeral pyre of her husband. The young woman whom he so dramatically saved from the cruel rites of the *Sati* was united in marriage to him. Children were born of this wedlock and after some years of happy married life she predeceased him. Charnock never married again and in loving memory of his wife always observed the anniversary day of her death and offered sacrifices by cutting off the head of a cock at her tomb "in the heathen fashion,

inspite of the opposition of the priests." According to his own wish his last resting-place is beside that of his dearly beloved wife and the mausoleum over his grave was built in 1694 by his son-in-law Sir Charles Eyre, the first President of Fort William.

Religious non-interference was the usual rule observed by Europeans with regard to their Indian wives. There could be no doubt that Charnock's wife was allowed to retain her original religion after her marriage with him. She being a Hindu it is difficult to explain why she was buried and not cremated, and why a goat was sacrificed considered unclean by Hindus was sacrificed at her tomb? The explanation may be that many Hindus who lose their caste by contact with non-Hindus become Bhoots, and after death are buried instead of being cremated. The evil spirit which is supposed in some instances to get hold of the body after death is propitiated by animal sacrifice. The Hindus who advised Charnock to adopt the aforesaid method of commemorating the anniversary of his wife's death must have satisfied themselves that she had become a *bhoot* or evil spirit on account of her having lost her caste due to her marriage with a European and to save themselves from this "ghost" arranged for the propitiation by the sacrifice of a cock, which is reputed to be highly relished by evil spirits and ghosts.

Charnock had two daughters. Mary, the elder, was married to Sir Charles Eyre and died shortly after he became the President of Fort William. She lies buried in the mausoleum by the side of her parents. The younger daughter Catherine married one Jonathan White. She also died at Calcutta in 1700 and was buried in St. John's churchyard. No trace of her grave can be found.

Doubts have been thrown on Charnock's having married an Indian woman and of her being the mother of his daughters Mary and Catherine. In support of this Col. Yule states that a European in

those days could not have dared to abduct a *Sati* widow from the pyre. This is hardly correct. Europeans were less conventional in [illegible] they are now, and the Chief of the [illegible] Titagarh could do much more than rescue a Hindu female from the cruel rites of *Sati* and then give the unfortunate outcaste, a home and the legal status of a wife. There is no proof to rebut the weight of the evidence of tradition handed down from both Indian and European sources. The fact of Sir Charles Eyre burying his wife in the mausoleum which he had built over the grave of the "Old Agent" who was buried alongside of his Indian wife lends colour to the theory that Lady Eyres was Charnock's daughter by this Indian lady.

From a correspondence, discovered by Col. Yule himself, in the British Museum Library, between Mary Eyre and Catherine Charnock, and Lady Wintworth, wife of Sir Henry Johnson, M.P., it seems that India was their land of birth.

Lady Johnson, while sending them a present writes :—

> "Could think of nothing ells to send believing yt in *your pleasant country* nothing can be a rarity but wt came from itt."

Calcutta.

The history of the development of the great city of Calcutta from three obscure and unhealthy villages in the marshy surroundings of the Gangetic delta from thatched huts and mud houses called *mulkothas* to the City of Palaces and the London of the East, not only reflects glory on the nation whose skill and enterprise have worked out this wonderful evolution but is also a demonstration of the triumph of sanitary science and engineering skill over dirt and disease for which old Calcutta was notorious.

The greatness of modern Calcutta is undoubted. There is hardly any place east of Suez which can vie

with it. Calcutta became the first capital of the great British Indian Empire, and inspite of the transference of the seat of government to Delhi in the words the the King-Emperor : " It still continues to be the premier city of India." It is certainly the largest in size and in trade in India and is next only to London in the British Empire. It possesses the greatest historical associations for the British and has the characteristics of a European town and affords more of the amenities of urban life than any other city in India. Its trade is greater than that of Bombay and Madras put together and its population at the census of 1921 was 1,327,547, which exceeds that of Bombay which comes next by nearly 72,862. The foreign trade in the port in the year preceding the great European War of 1914 amounted to 65 crores of rupees and exports [illegible] 93 crores.

One cannot however refrain from remarking that even inspite of the activities of the " Improvement Trust " there is in modern Calcutta a confusion of very superb and very lowly houses. Dead walls, huts, warehouses and godowns built without any idea of symmetry in the midst of fine pucca buildings, jar one's sense of the beautiful and the sublime. The splendid river front could also be immensely improved by substituting the ugly warehouses by a grassy bund and promenade, as a green fore-shore to the Strand Road with its magnificent buildings as the background.

Although I have given in detail my reasons for not accepting the ancient theory that the site of Calcutta was chosen by chance, as a mid-day halt of Charnock, I cannot help quoting from Rudyard Kipling's ditties, the following most appropriate description of this city :—

" Thus the mid-day halt of Charnock more's the pity
Grew a city

As the fungus sprouts chaotic from its bed
So it spread

Chance directed, chance erected, laid and built,
On the silt

Palace, myre, hovel, poverty and pride,
Side by side,

And above the packed and pestilential town,
Death looked down."

It must be admitted that the climate of Calcutta is still considered by up-country people as rather enervating and its fog in the winter months and its humidity in the summer are certainly annoying.

Modern Calcutta nevertheless is perhaps the healthiest and cleanest town for its size in India, and cannot be called pestilential. The triumphs of sanitary engineering and scientific town-planning, providing efficient drainage and good water supply have eradicated diseases like cholera, dysentery, diarrhœa, malarious and enteric fevers which were the scourge of old Calcutta and they are no longer endemic in this town.

The Old Fort.

After the death of Charnock the settlement founded by him continued to progress and develop. A local rebellion was utilised as an excuse for the construction of a fort in 1693 the need for which had been felt for many years, in order to safeguard the commercial and industrial interests of the Company. This was the old fort which occupied the site now bounded by the East Indian Railway House in Fairlie Place on the north, and the General Post Office and Koila Ghat Street on the south. The river which in those days flowed where now the Strand Road runs formed the western, and Dalhousie Square with its tank was its eastern, limits.

The defences of the settlement were further strengthened by means of big entrenchments on its outside limits when the Mahratta raiders in 1742 attacked Bengal and appeared on the opposite bank of the river and captured the fort of Makwa Tana

opposite Garden Reach. The entrenchment was called the "Mahratta Ditch" and followed the course of the modern Lower Circular Road.

Captured by Seraj-ud-Dowla.

The prosperity of Calcutta continued unabated till it was captured by Siraj-ud-Dowla in 1756. The defences had been neglected on account of the growing sense of security and the guns of the fort and of the [illegible] got masked by the surrounding buildings which were allowed to be constructed without any consideration of possible military requirements. The English had not expected the [illegible] the Nawab began hostilities and by swift marches arrived in front of the very gates of Calcutta. The presence of his army caused the greatest [illegible]. Governor Drake and many other officials [illegible] the ships which weighed anchor and soon dropped down the river and thence withdrew to Madras. The garrison was left to its fate, but put up a stubborn defence under the leadership of a gallant Irishman named John Zephania Holwell till it was driven to surrender. He and his companions numbering 146 men and women were according to tradition confined for the night in the prison of the fort, a small room measuring 18 by 14 feet. Ventilation was provided in this room by means of only two small grated windows. The heat was intense, the closely packed crowd endured terrible sufferings and when the morning came and the door was opened only 23 were found alive. This is known as the Black Hole Tragedy. (For full details, *vide* descriptive notes, pages 64—67.)

Black Hole Tragedy.

Calcutta was recaptured by Clive and Admiral Watson early in 1757. The prosperous Muhammadan town of Hooghly was bombarded in retaliation, and the sufferings of the victims of the Black Hole was avenged. The Battle of Plassey was fought

and Nawab Siraj-ud-Dowla's army defeated and dispersed. He was deposed and his Commander-in-Chief, and Pay-Master-General, Mir Muhammad Jaffar Ali Khan who had helped the British and entered into a secret treaty with Clive, was put on the *Musnad* of Bengal by the English. Siraj-ud-Dowla fled from Murshidabad, but was captured in the hills of Rajmahal and brought as a captive to Murshidabad where Sadeq Ali Khan, commonly known as Miran, the eldest son of Mir Jaffar, had him put to death.

The Company's Rule Established.

The Company were given adequate indemnity by the Nawab. Heavy compensation was also paid to the merchants by the Nobles and the State. A part of the money received from the Nawab was utilised by Clive to build a new fort. The inhabitants of Gobindapur were removed and the jungles cleared and the foundations of the present Fort William were laid. The clearing of the jungle round the glacis of the fort by Clive led to the formation of the famous *Maidan*, an open space, of which Calcutta is justly proud. The fort was finished in 1773, and since then the town of Calcutta has gone on expanding and flourishing uninterruptedly.

It is remarkable how the power of organisation and the spirit of enterprise of a handful of British factors steadily augmented the prestige and power of the East India Company, to such an extent that within one short century they were in a position to dictate terms to the Nawab Nazims of Bengal, who henceforth became their nominee.

In 1765, Clive obtained from Shah Alam II, Emperor of Delhi, a *Firman* making over to the East India Company the *Dewani* (Revenue Administration) of the provinces of Bengal, Bihar and Orissa. At the same time the Company also took upon itself the military defence of the country. Thus within a short time after the Battle of Plassey the British became the *de facto* rulers of the country, while the

power and influence of the descendants of Mir Jaffar [illegible] mere figureheads in the administration of the *Nizámat* of Bengal. [illegible], the famous capital of the Nawabs of Bengal, gradually fell into decay, [illegible] the headquarters of British trade and [illegible] rose to eminence and became the seat of the Governors-General of the British Company who ruled over Bengal and the adjoining provinces.

The Company organised a large and well-disciplined army recruited from the martial races of India, but trained and led by British Officers. Favoured by intercommunal feuds and the disorder and unrest following the dismemberment of the Moghul Empire, they extended their sway by degrees to other parts of India. "[illegible] *jai*"* rose above the din of [illegible] field in the country and reverberated from the plateau of the Nilgiris to the heights [illegible] from the sea-shore by the [illegible] of Assam, and the voice of the Governor-General at Calcutta became paramount in Indian politics.

India under the British Crown.

In 1857, a hundred years after the Battle of Plassey the Sepoy Mutiny broke out and spread like wildfire throughout the length and breadth of the country and very nearly subverted British supremacy in India. After this great crisis the rule of the East India Company was terminated by a Royal Proclamation of Her Majesty Queen Victoria on 1st November 1858, and India came directly under the British Crown.

It proclaimed the principle of justice and religious toleration and granted a general amnesty to all mutineers, except those who had directly taken part in murders.

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* Means "Victory to the valiant and the great Company." It was the hurrah of the Company's Indian troops called Sepoys by the Europeans. Sepoy is a corruption of the Persian word Sepáhí, meaning a soldier.

The Proclamation said—

"Our subjects of whatever race or creed be freely and impartially admitted to offices in our service, the duties of which they may be qualified by their education, ability and integrity, duly to discharge."

The Act of Parliament for the better government of India laid down that India should be governed by the sovereign of England through a Secretary of State assisted by a council of members and bestowed on the Governor-General of India the title of Viceroy. The last Governor-General, Lord Canning, became the first Viceroy of India and Calcutta became the capital of the British Indian Empire.

Lytton Durbar.

A closer association between English sovereigns and India was established in 1877 during the Viceroyalty of Lord Lytton. This gifted statesman captured the imagination of the people of this country by inaugurating a most gorgeous and magnificent Durbar at the old capital of the Great Moghuls. At this the first "Delhi Durbar," resplendent with all the pomp and power of Royalty, and surrounded by the Princes and People of India, the Viceroy proclaimed the assumption of the title of "Empress of India" by Her late Majesty Queen Victoria.

[PART II.]

Physical Geography.

Climate, Drainage and Water Supply.

Calcutta is situated in latitude 22° 23′ 47″ N. and longitude 880° 23′ 34″ E. It is very flat and is only 16 to 19 feet above the sea-level and 86½ miles from the sea. It is subject to violent cyclones and hurricanes which sweep up from the Bay of Bengal and cause great destruction to the shipping on the river and to the trees and houses on shore. They are generally associated with the commencement and the end of the south-west monsoon. Calcutta is also liable to shocks of destructive earthquakes.

It is admitted that in remote ages the whole of lower Bengal was a hilly country which by successions due to earthquakes became a tidal swamp referred to by the early Hindu writers as "*Samatata*" which literally means level of the sea, and that the country has since gradually risen by a process of alluvial deposits forming a comparative highland fit for human habitation; hence a rich silt is found in the soil of Calcutta and the adjacent country.

From December 1835 down to April 1840, a series of boring operations were conducted under the superintendence of a committee of naturalists. The hole bored in Fort William to a depth of 460 feet below the mean sea-level proved that the soil consists of alternate layers of clay and sand to about 40 feet below the surface beyond which is quicksand. There are also peat beds at 30 to 35 feet and again at 382 to 395 feet, and fine sand and pebbles like those of the sea-shore at a depth of 170 to 180 feet and at 320 to 325 feet, as well as gneissic rocks.

Digging operations in connection with the foundation of buildings and excavations of deep tanks have not only shown the characteristic of the soil described above, but stumps of Sundri trees have on occasions been found standing upright embedded at short intervals. These prove that the country must have been at no great distance of time in the same condition as the Sunderbands are at present, the subsidence of land having taken place as the result of earthquakes, and repeated deposits of silt in a tidal swamp has resulted in gradual reclamation in subsequent years.

Calcutta has got an essentially tropical *climate*. The temperature varies considerably, the extreme absolute range exceeds 53°, the maximum being 106° and the minimum 52.7°. The most unhealthy time are the months after the end of the rains and the most enjoyable are the winter months. Calcutta has three seasons; from November to the end of

February is the cold season, the hot months are from March till the second week of June, when the rains break; the wet season continues till September or the beginning of autumn. The coldest time of the year is the last week of December, and May is the hottest month. Those who can afford it, migrate to the hills during the hot months and again in September after the rains.

The humidity of Calcutta is very high. The average rainfall is about 66.04 inches. The greatest rainfall occurs in August and the least in December. The average atmospheric pressure in Calcutta 19 feet above the sea-level is 29.793 inches. It attains the highest point in December when it is 30.011 inches and its greatest [illegible] June and July with 29.551 inches. The barometer rises and falls twice during the 24 hours with clock-like regularity. The late Father Lafont of the St. Xavier's College stated that from about 4 A.M. the mercury rises slowly and steadily till about 9-30 A.M., then it begins to sink back in the tube till 4 to 5 P.M. Thus we have two maxima and two minima occurring very nearly at the corresponding hours of day and night.

From the earliest time the insanitary condition of the town attracted the notice of the authorities. The *drains* were merely irregular furrows in the soil left in a most filthy and uncleaned state and emitting the most offensive effluvia. The bottom of the drains were several feet below their supposed outlets, and the deposit of the putrid black and fermenting filth at the bottom consisting chiefly of the contents of the privies mixed with other organic matters in every stage of decomposition, gave off when disturbed, so disagreeable a stench that it was questionable whether it was prudent " to arouse its latent offensiveness." In the Fever Hospital Committee Report, Dr. W. Graham states :—" I had never found amidst this wilderness the green spot in which a philanthropic soul could repose and exclaim *hic sanitas*."

A Muslim new-comer very appropriately describes in Persian verse the [illegible] Calcutta in the time of Sir [illegible] 1798)—

آب شور و زمین سراسر شور * شور فرمان روای کلکته

داد و اسهال و خارش و پیچش * این همه تحفهای کلکته

Translation.

The water is brackish (shore),

The soil is impregnated with saltpetre (shore),

"Shore" is the Governor of Calcutta.

Ringworm, diarrhœa, itches and dysentery are amongst the presents a new-comer receives from Calcutta.

(The word "shore" in Persian means brackish, barren and also salt impregnated. The poet has made a play on the word "shore" which was the surname of the Governor-General of the time.)

The first effort at good drainage was made by Lord Wellesley in 1803. Although Lord Dalhousie also tried to improve it, nothing appears to have been done towards the construction of an efficient drainage system until 1855. The scheme was sanctioned in 1857 and took 25 years to complete at a cost of more than 95 lakhs of rupees. The main and branch sewers drained the area of the city bounded by Circular Road, the Mahratta Ditch and the river Hooghly.

By gradual development and the expenditure of another 68 lakhs of rupees the town was supplied with a complete system of covered drains and sewers and thus Calcutta at last got an efficient water-borne system for the disposal of its sewage.

In olden times Calcutta depended for its *water-supply* on the river and on big tanks called "Dighis" of which the most famous was the "Lál Dighi" in Dalhousie Square. There were many tanks reserved for drinking purposes throughout the town. Wells were also requisitioned as a

source of supplying drinking water, but they were "shallow" as the subsoil water was close to the surface and therefore their water was neither safe nor good. Much of the sickness and pestilential diseases from which the inhabitants of Calcutta suffered in its earlier days must have been due to defective water-supply, bad drainage and want of conservancy arrangements. Lord Dalhousie was quick to recognise that one of the chief needs of Calcutta was the supply of good drinking water. As has already been mentioned he also considered the need of introducing a proper system of sewerage and drainage. About the year 1820 a system of open raised culverts was constructed in a few of the principal streets from which people would obtain water and which also served for feeding the larger tanks in the town when the level of water in them went down during the dry months. The water was pumped from the river into a settling tank from which it gravitated into the culvert. This method, of course, did not prevent contamination of the tanks from a polluted river or of the water while it was passing through the culverts. A culvert of this type can be seen to the east of the Eden Gardens —the old settling tank is still in use in connection with the supply of water to the adjacent swimming bath. The first attempt to supply filtered water to the town was commenced in 1867 and took three years to complete. A supply of six million gallons of filtered water per day at 15 gallons per head was estimated and the project cost 67 lakhs of rupees. With the inclusion of the Southern Suburbs in the main area, arrangements were made for supplying 20½ million gallons per day. Up to March 1908, the filtered water undertaking cost Rs. 1,92,73,730. The rapid growth of population rendered further extension necessary. The improved scheme provides for a supply of 40 million gallons of filtered water per day. A pumping plant at Pulta now puts pressure on the mains to Calcutta through which water

formerly flowed only by gravitation. There is also a large reservoir of 9 million gallons capacity at Tallah into which filtered water is pumped. From here it gravitates throughout the town and the tank also acts as a reserve if the pumps at Pulta fail. The water-supply is obtained from the river Hooghly at Pulta which is about 17 miles above Calcutta. Here the water is put into settling tanks to allow the matters held in suspension by the water to go down and settle with the assistance of a small quantity of alumino-ferric which helps the process of sedimentation which is very necessary during the rains when the water gets muddy. From these settling tanks the water is conducted slowly to sand filter-beds and after filtration flows by gravitation to collecting wells and is thence pumped through two cast-iron mains of about 4 feet diameter to the overhead reservoir at Tallah, the capacity of which is 9 mililon gallons.

In order to meet the demand for the purpose of watering the roads and gardens, as well as for flushing the sewers and water-closets, a supply of unfiltered water was also introduced and the old pumping machinery utilised for this purpose. This gives a supply of 20 million gallons per day. There are two complete distinct systems of mains for filtered and unfiltered water laid throughout the town.

Area, Population, Sickness and Mortality.

The area of modern Calcutta with its suburbs is 42 sq. miles with a population of 1,327,547, of which 940,841 are Hindus and 325,093 Muhammadans. Calcutta proper, excluding the suburbs, has an area of 32 sq. miles with a population of 907,851.

In 1922, there were 19.1 births and 29.1 deaths per 1,000 of population, calculated on the census taken in 1921. The infant mortality is 287 for every 1,000 births. More than a fourth of the total number of children born in Calcutta die before they are one year old, and over a third of the deaths occur during the first week of their lives. In my booklet

on "Child Welfare" I have attempted to point out that 90 per cent. of infant mortality is due to causes which can be easily avoided such as premature births, debility, bad feeding and dirty and defective midwifery. All these causes can be prevented by the care of the expectant mother and the new-born infant; and I commend these facts for the serious consideration of my countrymen as a most important factor from the point of view of nation-building.

The mortality in Calcutta is highest in the month of April, and generally higher between October and April than in the other period of the year. From the latter part of June to September, that is during the rainy season when the country is thoroughly flushed out, the mortality is lowest. Cholera and plague generally show their virulence during the months of March and April. Malaria is most prevalent during the months immediately following the rains, namely, from the end of September to the beginning of December. This is the time when the malaria mosquitoes called *Anophiles* breed in stagnant and dirty puddles and marshy ground. The importance of using mosquito nets in Calcutta as a preventive measure against malarial fever, specially during these months, is apparent.

Dysentery and Diarrhœa are most prevalent before the beginning and in the early part of the cold season.

CHAPTER II.

Arrival in Calcutta.

Calcutta is approached by three distinct railway systems and also by the river. The East Indian Railway and the Bengal-Nagpur Railway terminate at the Howrah station, which is situated in the trans-Hooghly suburb of Calcutta on the west bank

of the river, and connected with Calcutta by a pontoon bridge. The Eastern Bengal Railway ends at the Sealdah station, in the city itself and is situated near the famous *Baithakkhana* associated with Charnock.

Sea-going vessels, inland steamers and river crafts of every description bring passengers into Calcutta and land them on the various jetties and ghats on the east bank of the river Hooghly.

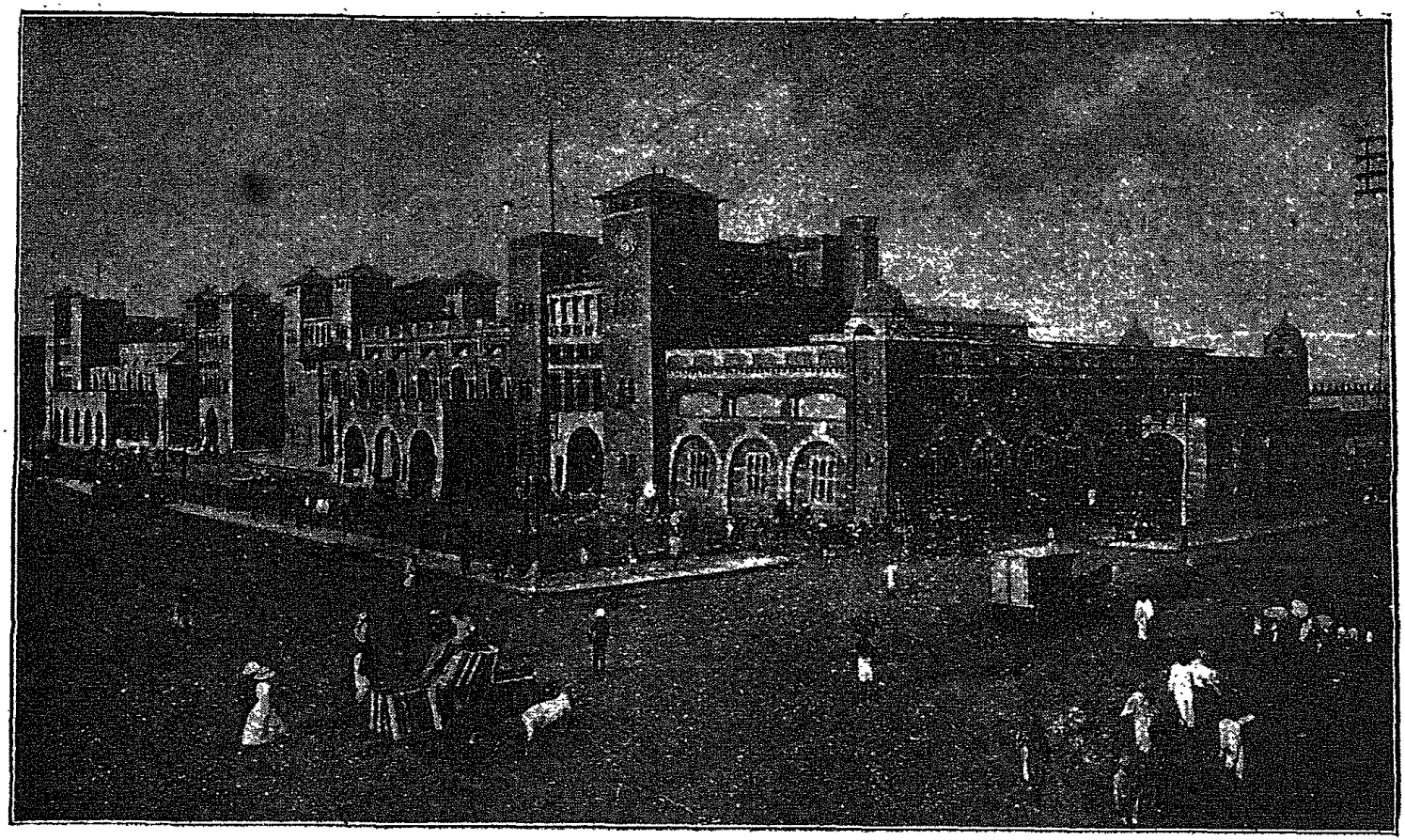
At the different railway stations and landing stages, porters called coolies and conveyances are always available. The drivers of taxi-cabs and phætons, rickshaws and the box-shaped "Bund Gharis" and bullock-carts for heavy luggage, coolies and hotel agents, all bustling and struggling to capture the stranger, must present a [illegible] to the new-comer to this London of the East.

It will be useful for the new arrivals from Europe and America to know that the official business hours in Calcutta are between 10-30 A.M. and 4-30 P.M. It is no use attempting to have an interview with any one in office before 11 A.M. The railway workshops and industrial undertakings, however, begin work early in the morning at about 7 A.M. Calcutta has a local time of its own which is 24 minutes in advance of the standard time, the Railway stations in Howrah and Sealdah and the sea-going vessels, however, observe the standard time.

The principal hotels, [illegible] the Great Eastern Hotel, the Spence's Hotel, the Continental Hotel are situated near Government House, and the business quarters.

Howrah Station.

The Howrah station is a magnificent building with a clock tower, constructed by the East Indian Railway Company in the Byzantine style of architecture. It belongs jointly to the East Indian and the Bengal-Nagpur Railway Companies. The



HOWRAH STATION.

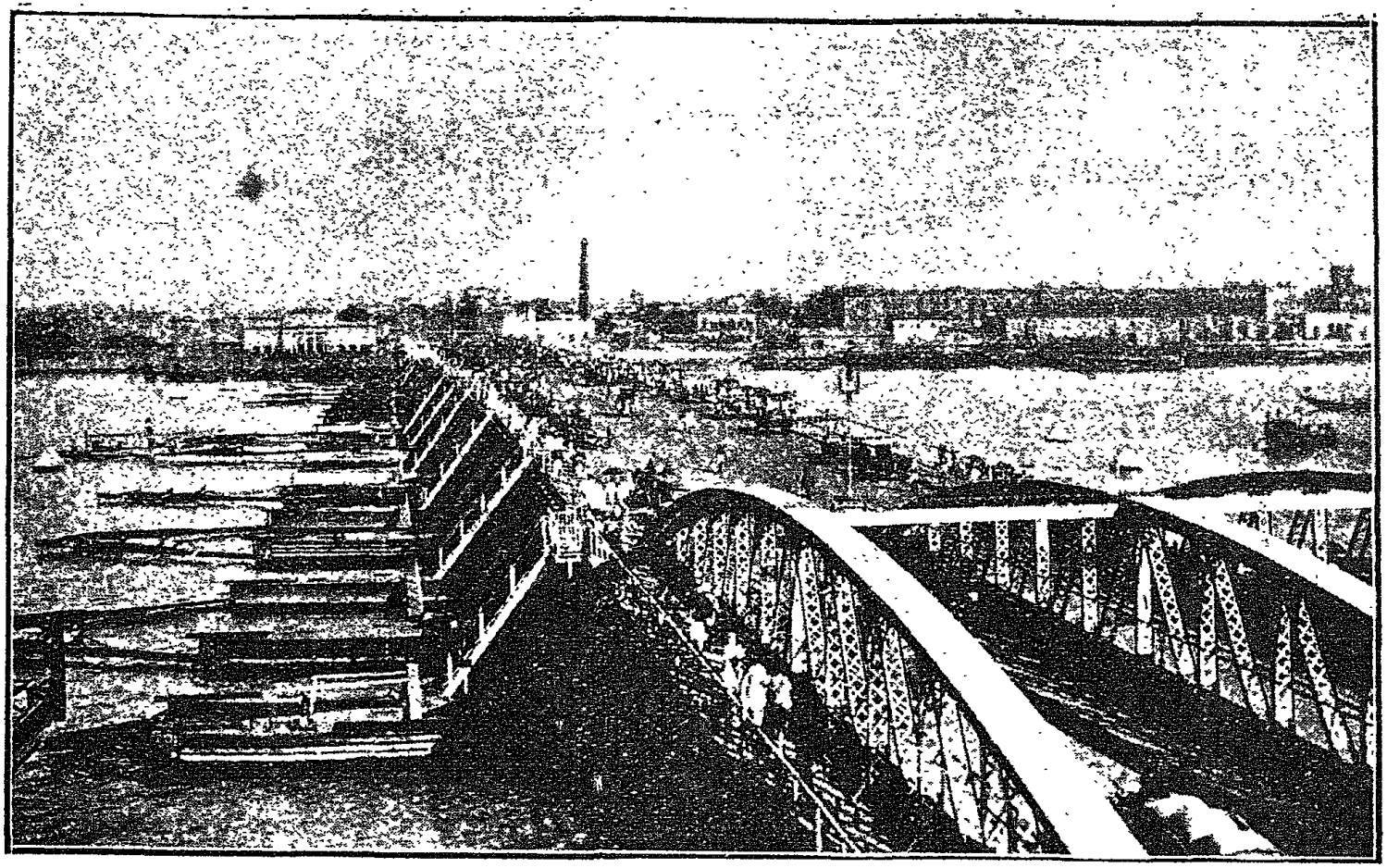
waiting rooms for passengers of the upper classes and arrangement for meals are most up-to-date and comfortable. Intermediate class passengers have separate arrangements. There is a large third class passengers' waiting hall, and lavatories for men and women in the Indian style. Zenana waiting rooms are also provided for "Purdah Nashin" females. Indian refreshments of all kinds can be obtained from Hindu and Muhammadan vendors. The stalls kept by them are under the supervision of a Food Inspector, maintained by the Railway Company. In the central hall opposite No. 9 platform on a raised enclosure is kept in view the first locomotive engine which carried passengers on the East Indian Railway in 1857.*

At the back of the 1st class booking office towards the north end of the main hall is a mural War Memorial of pretty design with the names of the officers and men of the East Indian Railway, who fell during the Great War of 1914-19.

The East Indian Railway is the pioneer railway in India. The first length of the line was opened on 15th August 1854. It now operates 2,772 miles of broad gauge railway (5′—6″ gauge) and carries over 34 million passengers and 14 million tons of goods per annum. About 24,000 passengers arrive and leave Howrah station every day.

The Bengal-Nagpur Railway is a very progressive and flourishing line and has developed very much of recent years due to the energy and enterprise of the promoters of the undertaking. It started as a metre gauge railway in 1878 and now operates over 2,716 miles including both broad and metre gauge lines. The first and second class carriages are very comfortable and provided with most up-to-date fittings.

* In order to make room for the new Enquiry and Booking Offices, this engine has been removed in October 1923, and placed in front of the gate of entrance to the Workshops at Lillooah.



HOWRAH BRIDGE.

Howrah Bridge.

The Pontoon bridge across the river Hooghly connects Calcutta with Howrah. It was originally constructed as a temporary measure and opened to traffic in October 1874; but the question of a permanent bridge has not been settled even up to the present day. The last New Bridge Committee reported in 1922 that, in view of the serious condition of the existing floating bridge and the grave consequences which would result from its failure, no time should be lost in providing a new bridge over the river Hooghly and that the bridge should be built of the cantilever type. Sir Bradford Leslie, C.E., K.C.I.E., built the present bridge: the structure is one of much novelty and originality in its design. It consists of 14 pairs of wrought-iron pontoons; the central portion is moveable and is removed at appointed times to allow ships to pass along the river. There is a footpath 7 feet wide at either side of the bridge and a roadway 50 feet wide in the centre for vehicular traffic. The bridge is 1,528 feet in length.

At either end of the bridge, the visitor will notice in the morning, an immense concourse at the *bathing ghats*, which have been built by pious Hindus. A mixed crowd of men and women will be seen taking their morning "dip," a practice which is considered a sacred duty.

CHAPTER III.

H. E. The Governor's Residence and other Important State Buildings.

Government House.

The first Government House in Calcutta was situated within the old Fort William and was an imposing building which elicited the praise of Captain Alexander Hamilton, who saw it in 1717 and

referred to it as "the best and most regular piece of [illegible] seen in the East." This house was discarded after the re-capture of Calcutta by Clive and Watson in 1757 and the President resided in the "Company House" on the river bank south of the old Fort. In 1767 a new site was selected for the third Government House on the Esplanade at the south-west corner of Old Court House Street. The Council House stood next door. This Government House was called Buckingham House, but it was neither imposing nor capacious. Public functions were as a rule held in the Court House, which stood on the site of the present St. Andrew's Church, or at the Play House which was in Clive Street, behind Writers' Buildings.

Grandpre, who visited Calcutta in 1790 in the days of Lord Cornwallis, speaking of the Government House, says :—"He lives in a house in Esplanade opposite the Citadel—many private individuals [illegible] as good: the house of the Governor of Pondicherry is much more magnificent." Warren Hastings also showed disinclination to live in this house and Lord Wellesley wrote in clear terms to the Court of Directors in London that "India should be governed from a Palace and not from a Counting House, with the ideas of a Prince, and not with those of a retail dealer in muslin and indigo." Accordingly, Captain Charles Wyatt, Bengal Engineers, was directed to draw up a plan. He designed the present building on a magnificent scale, the architecture being technically classified as the Queen Anne and Georgian pedimented and portico style. The buildings stand on more than six acres of well-laid-out grounds between the Maidan and the Eden Gardens, and command a clear view of over two miles to the south. The grounds of the present Government House absorb the site and enclosures of the old Government House and the adjacent Council House. The construction cost about 13 lakhs

of rupees, the land Rs. 80,000 and the furniture Rs. 50,000. The foundation-stone was laid on the 5th February 1799, and the building was formally opened with a public reception on May 4th 1802, the third anniversary day of the fall of Seringapatam.

There are two magnificent gates on the east and on the west. Each has a lion dominating the huge masonry archway and resting one foot on a sphere representing the globe and is flanked at a lower level by smaller arches surmounted by a crouching sphinx. These gates are used for public entrance and exit. The entrance to the grounds facing the main building is to the north. The visitors' book is kept here. This gate is of pretty design with stone pillars capped by ornamental urns of the same material. The Royal Crest is seen worked in gold on the iron gates and two *Sawars* of H. E. the Governor's Body Guard are on duty here. The north gate leads to a magnificent flight of steps on which Calcutta society assembles to welcome incoming Viceroys and Governors. The ordinary entrance to the building is below under the stairs. On the south side is the gate used in 1911 for the State entrance of H. M. the King-Emperor George V. It bears the Royal Crest and the letters G. R. I. in gold. This gate is now used as the private entry gate. The general design of Government House is borrowed from Kedleston Hall in Derbyshire, the ancestral house of Lord Curzon. The central building is connected by passages to four distinct wings. Each annex is practically a separate house. The rooms are so planned that a current of air passes through all, no matter from which quarter the wind blows.

The Government House contains a fine collection of portraits of Governors-General of India and marble busts of the Caesars taken from a French ship at the end of the 8th century. There are also pictures of George III, of Louis XV and his Queen

by Carle Von Loo, said to have been captured from the French at Chandernagore in 1757, of the Duke of Clarence, the Duke of Wellington, and many others, and also of the sons of Tipu Sultan.* The room in which the Levee is held is called the *Throne Room*, so called from the fact that the throne of Tipu Sultan was kept here after its removal from Mysore.

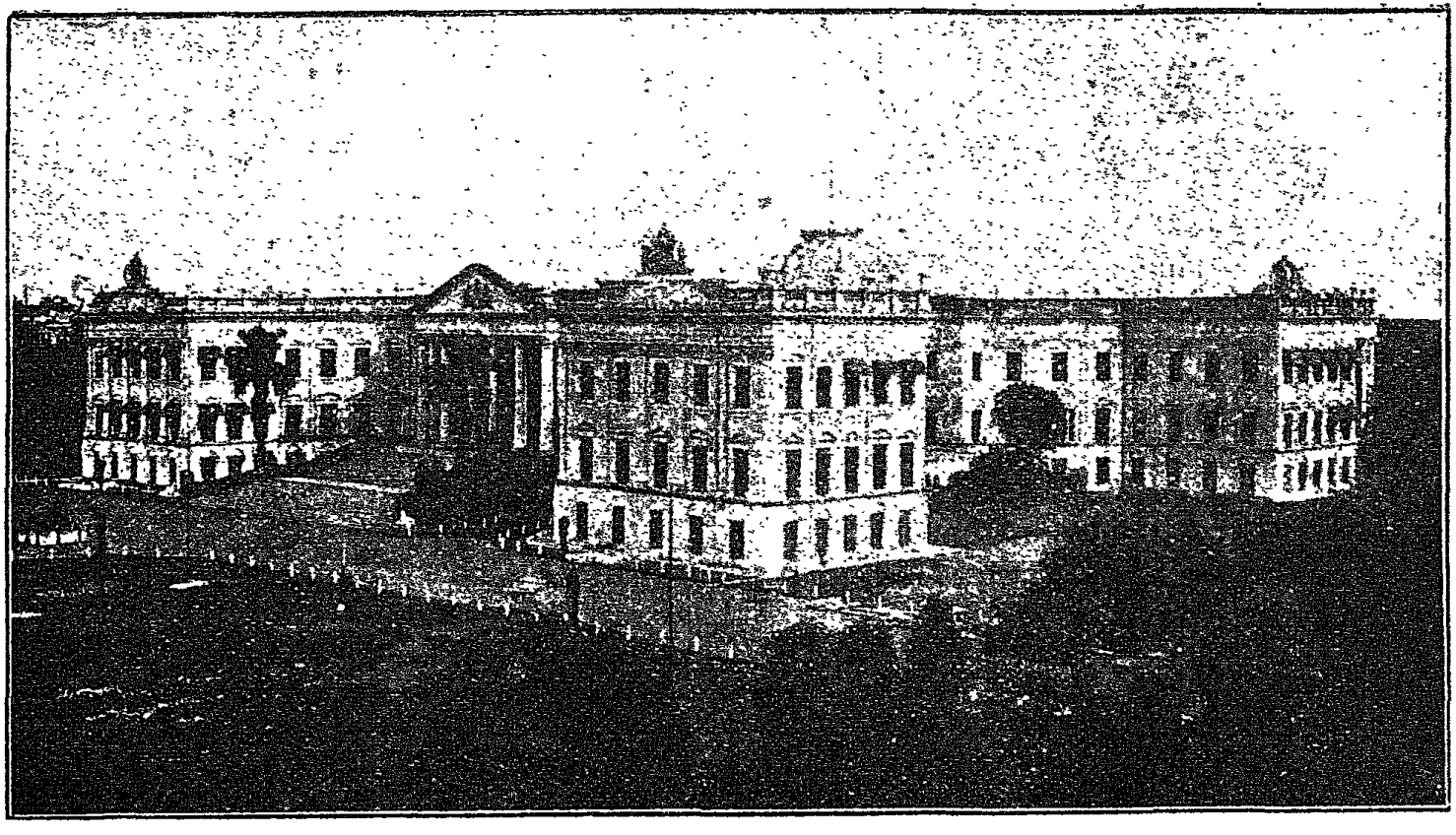
The centenary of the opening of Government House was held by Lord Curzon in 1902. During the State Ball they put on dresses of the period of 1802, and Lord Curzon impersonated Lord Wellesley. There was a pecu[illegible] things in the coincidence that this great Viceroy should celebrate the occasion, for apart from the association of Government House and Kedleston Hall, Lord Curzon like Wellesley understood what the *Izzat* or dignity of *Badshahat* or Sovereignty in the East meant and required.

Fort William.

The idea of building a new fort was mooted by Clive in August 1757 on his return from Murshidabad after putting Nawab Mir Muhammad Jafar Ali Khan on the throne of Bengal. Captain Brohier seems to have elaborated and planned the Fort.

The village of Gobindapur was cleared by Clive after giving sufficient compensation to the people who were induced to take away their patron deity Gobindji with them, and the tiger-infested jungle was reclaimed and the work commenced by Brohier at the end of the October 1757. The Fort was completed in 1773 at a cost of 2 million sterling. A large amount of money was spent in driving spikes to strengthen the banks and ward off the encroachment of the river. There was great difficulty in getting labour and the Company had to

* This collection of pictures have been removed in 1921 to the Viceregal Lodge at Delhi.



THE GOVERNMENT HOUSE (North view showing the Grand Stair Case).

resort to issuing orders that till the Fort was finished no one would be allowed to build a house of any kind in or about Calcutta and all brick-layers and coolies were impressed for the public service. This is the *bâegâr labour* work referred to by old Indians, as the labourers got only a small subsistence allowance for the work and the rates were lower than those offered by private persons. The adjoining area now known as Hastings is still called *Cooli Bazar* by the Indians as the labourers working at the Fort took up temporary quarters at the place.

Special permission for visiting the Fort should be obtained from the Military authorities or by applying through the Chief Secretary to the Government of Bengal or to the Commissioner of Calcutta Police. It is a town in itself. The two messes inside it are of historic interest—one was the special residence of the Commander-in-Chief and as such was occupied by Lord Roberts and Lord Kitchener, and the other which is known as the Outram Soldiers' Institute and served as the residence of the Governor-General, Lord Wellesley, during the construction of the new Government House. Bishop Heber also lived here when he first arrived in India. The last king of Oudh, Wajid Ali Shah, lived in these quarters from 1856 for three years till he went to live in the palace built for him in Garden Reach.

The Stronghold has got seven gates—one called the Water Gate, faces the river near the Gwalior Monument, another called the Royal Gate, faces Chowringhee and is also known as the Chowringhee Gate, the Plassey Gate leads to the south of the Government House and the Calcutta Gate leads to the Eden Gardens, St. George's Gate, called by the Indians *Cooli Darwaza*, faces Hastings or Cooli Bazar; near the General Hospital and the seventh entrance called the Treasury Gate is dominated by the quarters of the Commander-in-Chief, now occupied by the General Officer Commanding the

Presidency and Assam District. The Fort is built in the shape of an irregular octagon—five sides facing the land and three the river. It is surrounded by a ditch which can be flooded with water from the river Hooghly. The buildings not being conspicuous above the surrounding country and also on account of the bomb-proof houses topped with earth it is called *Zamin-ka-Killa* or the Fort at the level of the earth in contradistinction to the old forts which used to tower high over the surrounding country. Fort William has not yet got its baptism of fire and its strength and security have not been tried. It is however reputed to be impregnable.

The glacis, the Esplanade and the *Maidan* belong to the Fort (*Killa*) the Maidan is therefore popularly called *Killa-ka-Maidan*.

His Majesty's Mint.

It is situated on the Strand Road north of Howrah Bridge. The best time for visitors is between 11 A.M. and 1 P.M., as between those hours molten silver is poured. Persons wishing to visit the mint should apply to the Mint Master. The words " application for pass " should be written on the corner of the envelope. Generally, parties of not more than five persons are allowed, but special permission may be obtained for a larger number. The Pass should be presented at the warder's lodge. The Mint occupies 18½ acres of land, and as the building stands on land reclaimed from the river, the foundations are 25½ feet below the level of the road. The architecture is Grecian Doric and the central portico facing the Strand is a half-size copy of the temple of Minerva at Athens. The foundation was laid in March 1824 and the building took six years to complete; the construction cost 13 lakhs of rupees and the machinery 11 lakhs. This is said to be the largest mint of its kind in the world. The silver mint was opened in 1831 and the copper mint in 1865. In normal times the output is six lakhs of rupees per day.

Under the pressure of [illegible] due to the great War the daily output [illegible] 20 lakhs in December 1918.

The visitors should not omit seeing the specimen coins preserved in special cases and the gold mohur [illegible] in 1835. A silver replica of the famous [illegible]n also be seen. It has been [illegible] one of the four originally struck and [illegible]e four allied Sovereigns of Great [illegible]. Russia and Austria.

Gold coin is no longer struck in the Calcutta Mint.

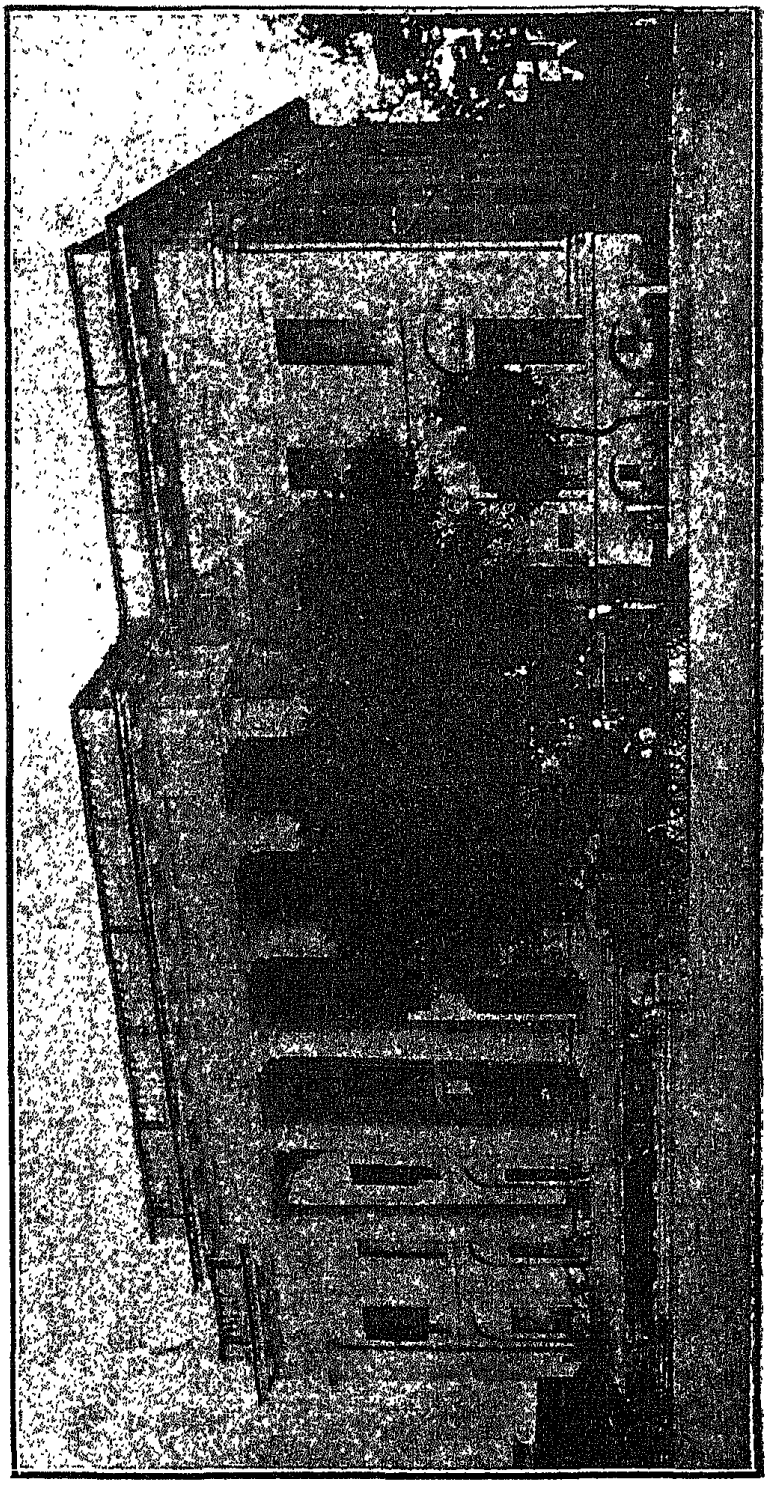
The mint or *Teksal* being [illegible] Emperors [illegible] Company until 1700 when a formal *Firman* for this purpose was received from Delhi, according to which the English were permitted to [illegible] from the Emperor of Delhi. It [illegible]e reign of King William [illegible] as first introduced. The [illegible] Lane opposite St. John's Church.

Shah Alum II was the last Emperor of Delhi to have a coin of his own which bore the following inscription :—

سکہ زد بر ہفت کشور شاہ فضل الٰہی
حامی دین محمد شاہ عالم بادشاہ

Translation.

The shadow of the favour of God, the Defender of the Faith of Muhammed, Emperor Shah Alum has struck the coin of the Realm current in seven kingdoms.



THE TOWN HALL.

Indian Institute of Public Administration.
Library, 6, Bhagwandas Road, New Delhi.
21-1-58.
9727

CHAPTER IV.

Some Prominent Public Buildings and Institutions.

Town Hall.

The Town Hall has been built on the site of the residence of John Hyde, one of the first three Puisne Judges of the Supreme Court. It is a large building of the Roman Doric style of architecture standing to the west of Government House, between the Treasury Buildings and the High Court. It was built at a cost of 7 lakhs of rupees raised by a series of annual lotteries. There is an English and a Persian inscription on a piece of stone let into the wall, one on either side of the southern portico, stating that the edifice was designed during the administration of Lord Wellesley and completed under the government of Lord Minto in the year 1813, the architect being John Garstin, Colonel of the Engineers. The magnificent flight of steps leading up to the southern entrance is chiefly used on ceremonial occasions, such as announcing the accession of the King-Emperors of India, or other important Royal proclamations. The ordinary carriage entrance is by the northern portico. The building consists of two storeys; the upper floor is boarded with teak, the lower hall is paved with white marble. The ground floor is now used as the Municipal Magistrates' Court rooms and also provides accommodation to their clerks and offices. The upper hall is divided into a central room and [illegible] of pillars and had a raised platform at the eastern and a music gallery at the western end and provided an admirable place for holding public meetings, receptions and dances.

In order to provide temporary accommodation for the enlarged Legislative Council after the Reforms the upper floor has been taken over by the Government of Bengal from January 1921. The

great saloon 172 feet in length and 67 feet in width has been divided into a central hall and two lobbies by putting up ferro-concrete walls between the pillars. The offices and library of the Legislative Department have been removed here from the [illegible]. The place has also been adapted to provide accommodation for a Committee room, [illegible] the President, the Members of the Executive Council, the Ministers and the Secretaries. Besides this there is a lounge for the use of the members of the Council. H. R. H. the Duke of Connaught formally opened the enlarged Legislative Council in this hall, on the 1st of February 1921.

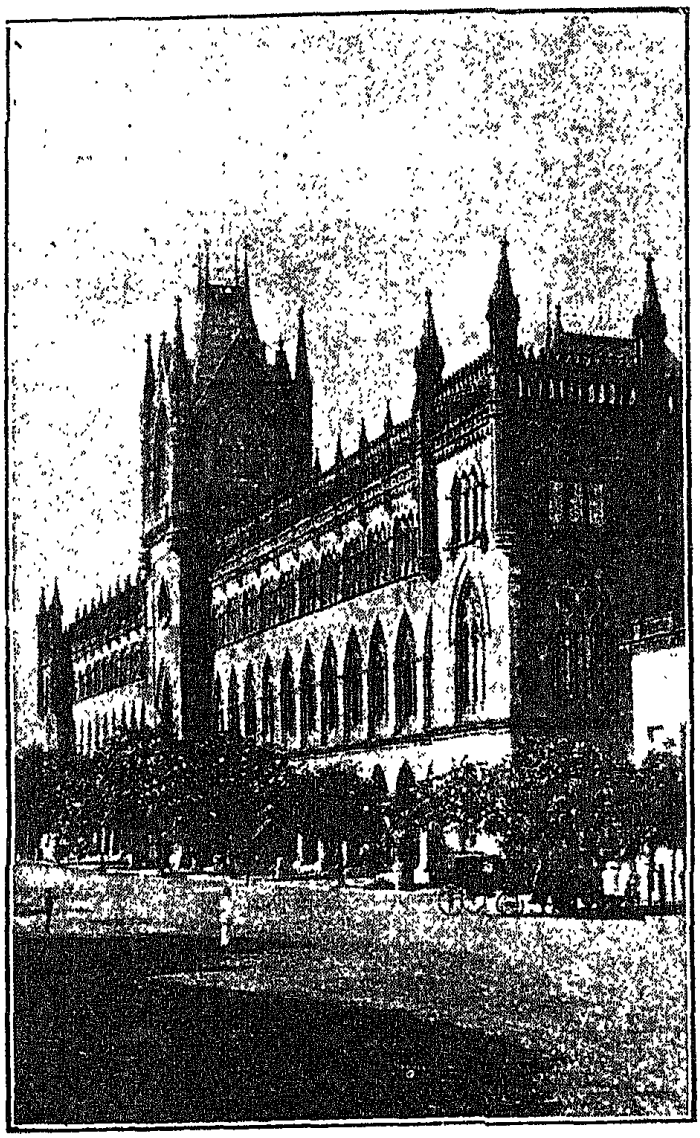
In the Town Hall there is a good collection of statues, busts and portraits of both British and Indian Notables of the country.

A sad incident is connected with this building. It was being utilised to provide some of the court rooms during the [illegible] while the Acting Chief Justice, Mr. Justice Norman, was leaving the premises he was stabbed to death on the steps of the northern entrance by a Wahabi fanatic, on 21st September 1871.

High Court.

The High Court is situated to the west of Government House almost at the junction of Esplanade West with Strand Road to the north of the Eden Gardens. It is one of the most imposing buildings in Calcutta built in somewhat florid Gothic style on the site of the old Supreme Court which occupied its western portion only. The builder was Mr. Walter Granville, the Government Architect. The general idea has been inspired by the Town Hall at Ypres. The foundations were laid in March 1864 and the work of construction completed in May 1872. The principal entrance is through the

handsome central tower on the south side which leads into the magnificent quadrangle of the building. Facing the Maidan is a beautiful row of pillars running along the lower storey. The capitols of the colonnade are of Cæn stone beautifully sculptured, each one having a different design, the study of which is well worth the trouble. The tower is 180 feet high and is 15 feet higher than the Ochterlony Monument, but the massiveness of the building conceals its real height. From this tower a panoramic view may be obtained of Calcutta and its environment, and on a clear day one can see the salt water lakes gleaming in the distance towards Belliaghatta. To the east of the quadrangle in Old Post Office Street is the carriage entrance for the public. There are private entrances for the Judges on the west and the east. On application to the caretaker, a guide is supplied to show



THE HIGH COURT.

the visitors all over the place. There is an excellent tram-car service to the High Court from all parts of the city.

In the archives of the High Court can be seen the papers relating to the famous trial of Nanda Kumar by Elijah Impey and of the case brought against Philip Francis by Grand (*vide* pages 50 and 86).

Indian Museum.

This is an imposing building on Chowringhee Road between Sudder Street and the United Service Club. It was opened to the public in 1875. It is built on the site of the old High School which in 1863 was transferred to Darjeeling and is now known as St. Paul's School.

"The façade has two stories of great height, in the Italian style [illegible] two projecting wings and the [illegible] having elegant Corinthian columns. [illegible] of steps leads to a lobby, which opens on either side into a room 80 feet by 30 feet. Three series of arches lead to a double staircase of very fine proportions ascending to the right and left, and beyond the foot of the staircase the lobby opens on to a [illegible] quadrangle 180 feet by 105 feet, [illegible] selection of tropical plants; around this the inner sides of the building form a piazza or arcade. The pairs of the arches are decorated on the side facing the quadrangle with engaged columns, in the Roman Doric style on the ground floor, and in the Roman Ionic on the first floor." ("Calcutta Old and New" —COTTON.)

The Museum is popularly known as *Jadu Ghar*. It is called *Ajaib Khana* or the House of Wonders in Persian and certainly contains a most wonderful collection of exhibits of archæological interest, and specimens of what please even the eye of the uninitiated, such as stuffed birds, fishes, reptiles and animals of all descriptions, not even omitting spiders,

centipedes and scorpions and [illegible] types of men from the hills and the islan[illegible] their boats, weapons and armour and models of their houses. The art gallery is very interesting and the great gold throne of Thebaw, the last king of Burma, can be seen here.

The west gallery of the first floor contains the library of the Geological Survey of India.

T[illegible]y mornings are reserved for students. [illegible] only Purdah ladies can visit the place. [illegible] a guide in attendance. The [illegible] pass the doors.

Art Gallery.

To the southern end of the Indian Museum in C[illegible] adjoining the U[illegible] Service Club are [illegible] of Art. [illegible] in 1854 under the [illegible] Society for the Promotion of Industrial Art. Besides teaching lithograph, wood-engraving, modelling, stencilling, fresco-decoration, lacquer work, the curriculum includes free-hand drawing, painting in oil and water colour, and architectural drawing. The plaster decoration in the old Bengal Legislative Council Chambers in Writers' Buildings is the work of the early pupils of this Institution under Mon. Rigaud.

The Government Art Gallery is open to the public. Here the visitor will notice among other examples of Indian Art a fine collection of paintings of the Hindu and Muhammadan periods.

Asiatic Society.

The Asiatic Society of Bengal, No. 1, Park Street, was founded by Sir William Jones, the then Chief Justice of Bengal, on the 15th of January 1784 with Warren Hastings as its first patron. The objects of the Society are well set out by its illustrious founder in his first discourse. He states that "the boundary of its investigations will be the

geographical limits of Asia and within these limits its enquiries will be extended to whatever is performed by man or produced by Nature." Since the foundation of the Society its literary activity has been uninterrupted and "the Journal of the Asiatic Society of Bengal" and "the Proceedings," contain materials of the highest interest in Science, Literature, Antiquity and Natural History.

A very important department of this Society, and one that has greatly added to its renown, is the *Bibliotheca Indica*. In 1835, the Court of Directors gave the Society a monthly grant of Rs. 500 for printing oriental works and since that time the Society has issued, under the above title, nearly a thousand fasciculi of numerous Sanskrit, Arabic, Persian, Pali and Hindi works, both in original and in translation, among them being a fine collection of the works of Indian historians. The monthly grant was continued, and in 1858 the Imperial Government increased it by Rs. 250 per mensem for the same purpose. In 1870 the Imperial Government sanctioned Rs. 3,200 per annum for the purchase and classification of manuscripts in Bengal.

The Museum of the Society up to 1866 contained a large collection of ethnological specimens, besides many archæological relics and statues of great value. These were offered to Government to be kept free in the proposed Imperial Museum. Thus the Asiatic Society supplied the nucleus of the present Indian Museum, and is therefore popularly called the *Parana Jadughar*.

The Library contains about 15,000 volumes, more than 5,000 of which are Sanskrit, Arabic, Persian and Hindi manuscripts. There is also a fine collection of Burmese, Nepalese and Tibetan manuscripts. The bulk of the Arabic and Persian manuscripts form part of Tipu Sultan's library which was transferred from Seringapatam to the College of Fort William. Among the manuscripts

are many masterpieces of caligraphy and oriental painting. The Society has a rich collection of copper *sanads*, portraits, pictures and busts and the collections are well worth inspection. The rooms of the Society are daily open to members from 10 A.M. to 5 P.M. Strangers may visit the Library and inspect the coins on applicatio[illegible]. The business of the Society i[illegible] Council chosen annually. The [illegible]e held on the first Wednesday [illegible].M.

Metcalfe Hall and Imperial Library.

It is situated at the junction of Hare Street and Strand [illegible] Metcalfe Hall was built by public [illegible] from the entire Indian community to perpetuate the memory of Charles Theophilus, Lord Metcalfe, who officiated as Governor-General of India from March 1835 to March 1836, in the interregnum between the departure of Lord William Bentinck and the arrival of Lord Auckland. He was called the "Liberator of the Indian Press" as the emancipation of the press was his greatest act of public life in India. A marble bust of Lord Metcalfe stood in the vestibule of the Hall, but after the conversion of the building into the Imperial Library by Lord Curzon, the bust has been removed to the Victoria Memorial Hall collection. The foundation-stone of the building was laid with Masonic rites on December 1840, the Governor-General being present. The building was completed in 1844. The architecture is adapted from the portico of the Temple of Winds at Athens and was designed by Mr. C. K. Robison. The building is raised on a solid and ornamental basement 10 feet high; from this 30 columns 36 feet in height support the general entablature of building in imitation of the style of Greek temples. For want of funds the columns and colonnades could not be carried round the entire building. There is a covered porch with colonnades to the east from which a flight of steps

leads up to the entrance hall. A broad flight of steps also leads to the colonnade to the west on the river front but this is not used. Formerly the Museum and Committee rooms of the Agricultural Society occupied the ground floor, while the Public Library occupied the upper rooms.

Lord Curzon noticed that the Public Library had languished under inadequate support and lax management and that the Agricultural Society had failed to attract public interest, and the building itself was in a state of bad disrepair. He founded the present Imperial Library in 1902 by amalgamating the old Calcutta Public Library with the Government of India Home Department Library which contained many books that formerly belonged to the library of the East India College at Fort William and to the library of the East India Board in London.

"The Imperial Library Council aim at making the Library one from which or through which any book may be obtained that any one in India may want."

A selection of English, Persian, Urdu, Hindi autograph letters, old maps of India, pictures and other objects of historical and antiquarian interest form a small *museum* in the hall. For want of suitable rooms they are kept in glass cases in the vestibule or hung on the walls.

The Bohar Library.—It consists of a collection of 950 Arabic and Persian manuscripts and one Turkish manuscript and about 1,500 printed books in Arabic, Persian and Urdu. This formed the family library of Munshi Syed Sadaruddin al-Musavi, Zamindar of Bohar, in the District of Burdwan. The library is catalogued and is useful for research purposes.

The Imperial Library is open from 10 A.M. to 7 P.M., and on an average 100 readers utilise the spacious reading rooms daily: admittance to the

private [illegible] is granted only to persons engaged [illegible] research work.

The Commercial Museum.

It is situated at No. 1, Council House Street, in the same building which contains the Board of Examiners. The exhibits occupy the first floor and is approached by the southern staircase of the building. The entire collection is of Indian manufacture. It is a recent institution, established in 1916; admittance is free and the Museum is open on week-days from 10-30 A.M. to 5-30 P.M., excepting on Saturdays when it closes at 2-30 P.M.

Commercial Library and Reading Room.

Attached to the Government Commercial Intelligence Department, situated in the same building as the Commercial Museum. It is open from 10-30 A.M. to 5-30 P.M. on week-days and from 10-30 A.M. to 2-30 P.M. on Saturdays. Admission free.

The Corporation Buildings.

The Central Municipal Offices situated in Corporation Street are contained in a building well worthy of the City. The main entrance is through the southern end surmounted by a tower. A broad flight of steps leads to a magnificent Council Chamber, the Committee rooms and the lobbies. There are some fine pictures, statues and busts to be seen here, also a Boer gun captured in the South African campaign and presented to the city in appreciation of the part played by the Indians in the Boer War. The history of the Calcutta Corporation dates from 1727 [illegible] a Mayor and nine Aldermen who bravely tried to keep down the insanitary conditions of Calcutta. In those days, drainage and conservancy arrangements were of the most primitive [illegible]

In 1780 Mackintosh states that "the very small portion of cleanliness which it (Calcutta) enjoys is owing to the familiar intercourse of hungry jackals by night, and ravenous vultures,

kites and crows by day. In like manner it is indebted to the smoke raised on pub[illegible] ; [illegible]'s and sheds for any respite it enjoys [illegible] productions of supply of Calcutta, [illegible]

Since 1793, the improvement in roads, building, drainage, sanitation and water supply was inaugurated, developed and executed from funds subscribed by lotteries. The Lottery Committee of Calcutta was established for this purpose and received Government authority in 1817, but in spite of the good work done by this institution for public benefit and charities, orthodox opinion in England was against this method of providing funds and the Committee was abolished in 1837.

(For the history of the development of drainage and water supply of Calcutta, *vide* pages 16 to 19.)

The present constitution of [illegible] Corporation is based on the Ben[illegible] Act, III of 1899. According to this [illegible] consists of a Chairman who is a [illegible] Indian Civil Service and 50 Commissioners, 25 of whom are elected from the different wards, four by the Bengal Chamber of Commerce, four by the Calcutta Trades Association and two by the Port Commissioners and 15 are nominated by the Government of Bengal.

There is a Corporation Club on the premises and a Library which is kept open from 10-30 A.M. to 5 P.M. The [illegible] of the Calcutta Corporation dur[illegible] Rs. 1,40,90,950 and capital incol[illegible] the expenditure on those heads [illegible] Rs. 1,51,62,543 and Rs. 25,79,712.

With the inauguration of the "Reforms" the Local Self-Government Department was placed in charge of the veteran leader of the people, the Hon'ble Sir Surendranath Banerjea. One of the epoch-making landmarks of his administration of this Department is the passing of the Calcutta Municipal Bill, in March 1923. The Act will come into force

in 1924. It has thoroughly democratised the Calcutta Corporation. The President of the Municipal Council will be elected and the executive head will no longer be appointed by Government. The representatives of the rate payers of the city will have the entire management of [illegible] in their hands. Plural voting has b[illegible] with and franchise has be[illegible] payers and it has been considerably lowered for everyone. The number of commissioners has been increased from 50 to 90, of whom 80 will be elected.

Calcutta Port Trust.

To the west of the General Post Office at the junction of Koilaghat Street and Strand Road are the Head Offices of the Calcutta Port Trust, containing the offices of the Chairman, Chief Engineer, Chief Accountant, Traffic Manager, Deputy Conservator and Harbour Master. The Port Officer and the Port Health Officer are located in the adjoining building to the north. A time ball is dropped from the tower at the south-western corner of the building at 1 P.M. daily.

Calcutta Improvement Trust.

Inaugurated in 1909. Office : 5, Clive Street.

The Bengal Chamber of Commerce.

The Bengal Chamber of Commerce was founded in 1834, when Lord William Bentinck was Governor-General and Thomas Babington Macaulay was Law Member. Little is known of its early days. There are no records earlier than 1851, when it was more or less reconstituted. For very many years it was housed in the Bengal Bonded Warehouse in Clive Street. But in 1893, the then President, Mr. James L. Mackay (now Lord Inchcape), acquired on its behalf the premises of the new Oriental Bank Corporation which was in course of liquidation. These premises stood at the corner of Clive Street and what was then known as Old China

Bazar Street. They were on what is reputed to have been the site of Clive's Government House, and later of the house in which Francis is said to have lived.

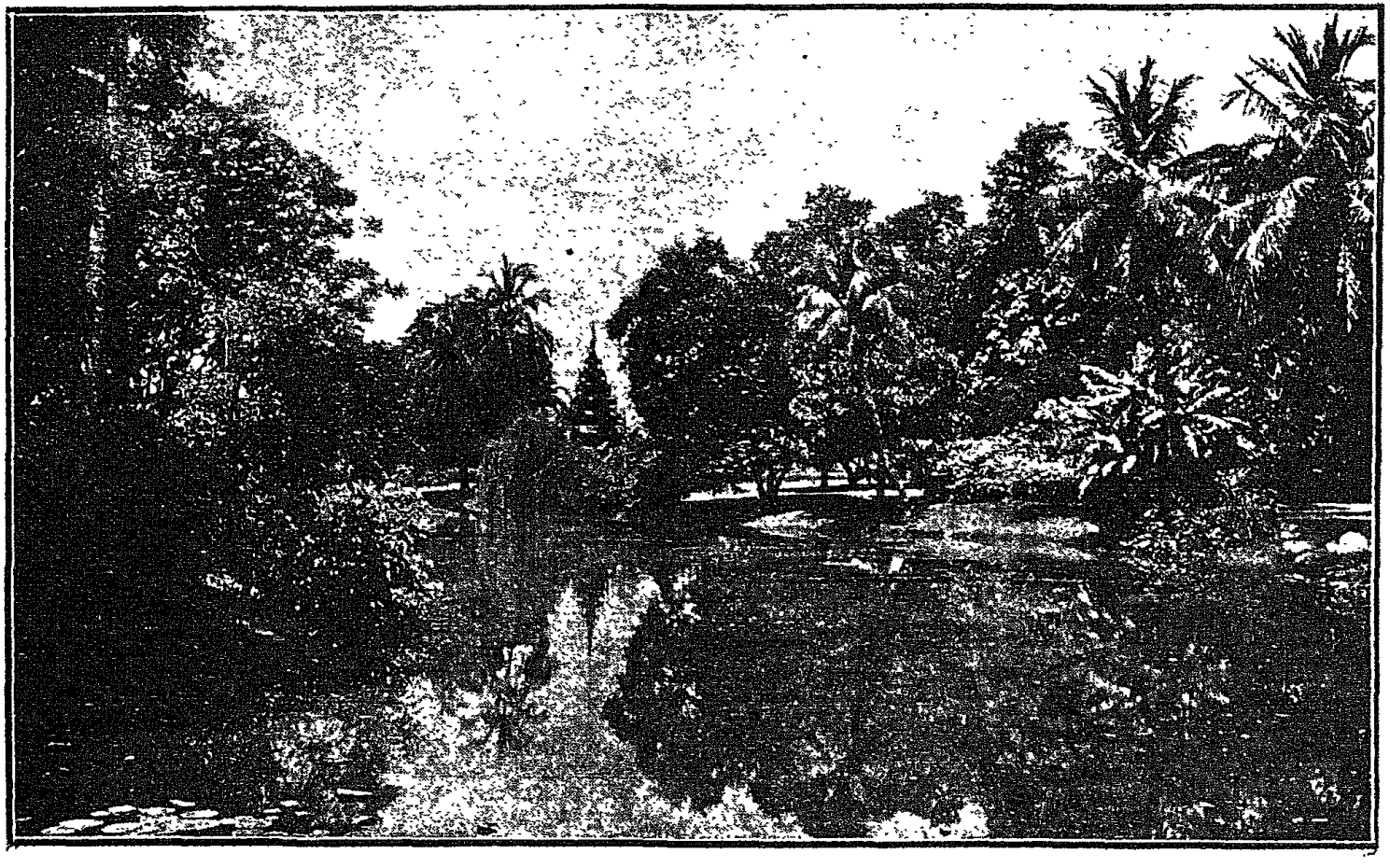
The Bank premises were utilised by the Chamber and the Royal Exchange until 1915, when they were demolished and the present Royal Exchange was erected. The establishment of a commercial exchange was mooted in Calcutta as far back as 1857; and in 1881 the organisation of a mercantile exchange was contemplated. But it was not until 1893, when the Bank premises were acquired, that the idea took practical shape. A mercantile exchange which by special permission of Queen Victoria was styled the Royal Exchange was then established as a part of the Chamber. The Exchange now consists of 1,016 members, and the Exchange Hall, which is a prominent feature of the new building, is used by members daily as a place of meeting for the transaction of business.

The Chamber itself was incorporated in 1893 as a public company under section 26 of the Indian Companies Act. Prior to that time it had been an unregistered Association of merchants, bankers, etc. It now consists of 240 members and may fairly claim to be thoroughly representative of the European trade, commerce, and manufactures of the city. It is managed by a President, a Vice-President, and a Committee of seven members who are elected annually by the members, and who conduct its business in accordance with the provisions of the Articles of Association. In addition to the work of the Chamber proper as represented by the Committee, there are no fewer than 22 commercial Associations recognised by the Chamber. They are the following:—Indian Tea Association, Calcutta Tea Traders' Association, Indian Jute Mills' Association, Calcutta Baled Jute Association, Calcutta Fire Insurance Agents' Association, Calcutta Marine

Insurance Association, Calcutta Wheat & Seed Trade Association, The Wine, Spirit and Beer Association, Indian Paper Makers' Association, Indian Engineering Association, Calcutta Jute Fabrics Shippers' Association, Calcutta Hydraulic Press Association, Jute Balers' Association, Calcutta Baled Jute Shippers' Association, Calcutta Jute Dealers' Association, Calcutta Hides and Skins Shippers' Association, Northern India Tanners' Federation, Indian Indigo Association, Calcutta Accident Insurance Association, Indian Lac Association for Research. The business of these Associations is transacted by the secretarial staff of the Chamber subject to the [illegible] and Sub-Committees.

Another important branch of the work of the Chamber is the measuring and weighing of most of the principal commodities exported from Calcutta. For this work, which is done mainly in the course of shipment, the Chamber has a special Department —the Licensed Measurers' Department—which has been in existence for thirty years. It maintains a staff of about 110 measuring officers who measure and weigh goods chiefly in course of shipment. The certificates of the measurements so recorded are used by the steamship companies as the basis upon which to calculate freights charged to exporters; and the certificates of weights are required chiefly by exporters for contract purposes. The number of packages measured during the year ended 30th June 1923, was 6,417,652, and the number of packages weighed was 10,262,892.

There is also in existence in connection with the Chamber a Tribunal of Arbitration for the settlement and adjustment of disputes and differences relating to trade, business, manufactures, etc. The Tribunal consists of the members of the Chamber, and it proceeds in accordance with the provisions of the Indian Arbitration Act, 1889. Its



THE EDEN GARDENS—BURMESE PAGODA AT A DISTANCE.

awards may be filed by either party to any particular dispute in the Calcutta High Court and be made a decree of the Court. The Tribunal transacts a considerable volume of business. In 1920, the number of cases instituted was 1,185, in 1921, the number was as high as 1,824, and in 1922, it dropped to 968.

With the inauguration of the "Reforms" the non-official European community are taking active part in the Public Life of the country. The Hon'ble Sir Alexander Murray, Kt., C.B.E., Member of the Council of State, Sir Robert Watson Smyth, Member of the Bengal Legislative Council, Sir Campbell Rhodes, Kt., C.B.E., Member of the Legislative Assembly are recent past Presidents of the Chamber of Commerce. The Chamber returns six [illegible] Legislative Council and the same number of representatives sit on the Calcutta Corporation.

The present President of the Chamber is Mr. W. L. Carey, Member, Bengal Legislative Council. The Secretary of the Chamber is Mr. H. H. Heywood, C.I.E., who is a permanent employee.

CHAPTER V.

Eden Gardens: the Strand and the Maidan: Memorials and Monuments.

The Eden Gardens.

The Eden Gardens are situated on the Strand lying directly south of the High Court. They are beautifully laid out and include what was once known as the Respondentia Walk, a tree-shaded avenue, which stretched along the river between Chandpal Ghat and the new Fort and once constituted the fashionable promenade of Calcutta society. Near the High Court entrance stands the statue of George Eden, the second Baron and first Earl of Auckland, during whose Governor-Generalship the

first Afghan War broke out. This most pretty garden and public grounds were laid out by Lord Auckland's sisters, and Hon'ble Misses Eden, famous for their literary and aesthetic attainments. It is for this reason that the Eden Gardens are still called by Indians "Lady Bagan." There is a Burmese Pagoda in the centre, brought from Prome as a war trophy in 1856.

The scene of an evening with the band playing and the beautiful grounds and ornamental waters spangled with electric lights recalls to an imaginative mind the beauties of "the Garden of Eden."

Strand Road (South).

Between the High Court and the Hastings landing stage, the Strand constitutes a fashionable place for Calcutta society to drive in motor-cars and open conveyances, enjoying the cool river breeze of an afternoon or listening to the band at the Eden Gardens.

There are a few places of interest in this length of the road.

Immediately to the west of the High Court is *Chandpal Ghat*. It is the favourite station for going on river trips by Port Commissioners' ferry steamer service or by private steam launches and boats. There is a good waiting room fitted with electric lights and fans. This ghat was the official landing stage where Members of Council, Governors-General, Commanders-in-Chief, Judges of the Supreme Court and of the High Court and Bishops alighted in India or departed for Europe under the boom of saluting guns from the ramparts of Fort William.

Now the departing and arriving Potentates, Viceroys, Governors and other notables, alight at the Howrah Railway Station and enter Calcutta *viâ* the Howrah Bridge, or they cross the river by a steamer and alight in state at Prinsep's Ghat, as was done when King George V visited Calcutta in 1906 and 1912.

Chandpal Ghat is mentioned as forming the southern boundary of "Dhee Calcutta" in 1774 and is named after Chandranath Pal, better known as Chand Pal, *modi* (grocer), who sold coarse refreshments to pedestrians and boatmen. In those days the surrounding country was uninhabited and full of jungle.

It has been truly said: "Upon what trifles do the momentous affairs of mankind appear to hang." While alighting at Chandpal Ghat, Philip Francis and his colleagues, Generals Clavering and Monson, are said to have counted 17 guns fired in their honour whereas they had expected 19. They never forgave the Governor Warren Hastings for this apparently deliberate slight. This incident seems to be at the bottom of that rancour and hatred between Warren Hastings and Francis and their personal differences in the Council which did not [illegible] morable duel but found an echo in the solemn trial in Westminster Hall.*

It was while landing at Chandpal Ghat with the Judges of the Supreme Court that Sir Elijah Impey is said to have looked at the crowd of Indian [illegible] their bare feet and uncovered bodies [illegible] his colleagues:

"See, brothers, the wretched victims of tyranny. The Crown Court was not surely established one day before it was needed. I trust it will not have been in operation for six months before we shall see all these poor creatures comfortably clothed in shoes and stockings."

---

* Phillip Francis with General Sir John Clavering and Colonel George Manson formed a party to obstruct Warren Hastings in his Council. With only Richard Barwell on his side the Governor-General found his position very difficult. Phillip Francis out of personal malice not only opposed even good and sound measures brought forward by Warren Hastings but instigated and engineered attacks on him. Among others Raja Nand Kumar was made to bring up a charge that Warren Hastings has received nearly four lakhs of rupees from Mani Begum of Murshidabad and a large sum of money from his son Garudas for their appointment in Murshidabad.

Opposite Chandpal Ghat are the Calcutta swimming baths and the premises of the Volunteer Head Quarters.

Baboo Ghat.—A little to the south of the High Court opposite Auckland Road, on the riverside, is a *pucca* ghat with Doric pillars. It is called Baboo Ghat after Baboo Rajchandra Das, the husband of the celebrated Rani Rashmani, whose residence can be seen at Jan Bazar, now called Corporation Street. It is used as a bathing ghat by respectable Indian gentlemen.

Opposite the Eden Gardens is *Outram Ghat* which [illegible] passengers to and from Englar[illegible] over it is a distinctive feature and on the upper storey of the pontoon there is a fine tea-house where light refreshments are served at very reasonable rates. The boat house of the Calcutta Rowing Club lies a little higher, immediately to the north of this ghat. Further north is the *Dharamsala* for Indian deck passengers for sea-going vessels.

Hastings refused to meet these charges in the Council and brought an action [illegible] for conspiring with his enemies.

The charge was admitted and Nand Kumar was released on bail. He was arrested about six weeks later on a charge of forgery and committed to be tried by the Supreme Court and to be kept a prisoner in the Presidency Jail. Sir Elijah Impey, the Chief Justice, tried Nand Kumar and condemned him to be hanged. (1775.)

The opponents of Hastings were thus disgraced, and he had [illegible] Indeed after the death of Monson, Warren Hastings' casting vote commanded the majority and [illegible] humble pie and return to England after the [illegible] (see 132).

Although the execution of Nand Kumar struck terror in the hearts of mischief makers against Hastings but it was an ill-advised act, as it produced a very bad feeling in the country. It is said, suppressed shouts of curses against the Company's rule were heard even among the crowd who witnessed the horrifying sight from the exposed gallows. The Brahmins turned terror-stricken towards the Ganges shouting *Bápre Báp* (Father save us) and plunged into the sacred stream to perform the bath of purification after witnessing such a sacrilegious sight.

The Gwalior Monument on the Strand is situated to the north-west of Prinsep's Ghat opposite Fort William. It is a kiosk built of brick, faced with Jaipur marble, surmounted by a metal dome and columns, made by melting the captured guns of the Gwalior campaign of Sir Hugh Gough. It was erected by the Earl of Ellenborough in 1847 The height is 58 feet 6 inches. In the centre of the upper storey is a sarcophagus on which are inscribed the names of officers, and men who fell in the campaign. The cupola has acquired a pretty greenish tint from age and exposure to the atmosphere.

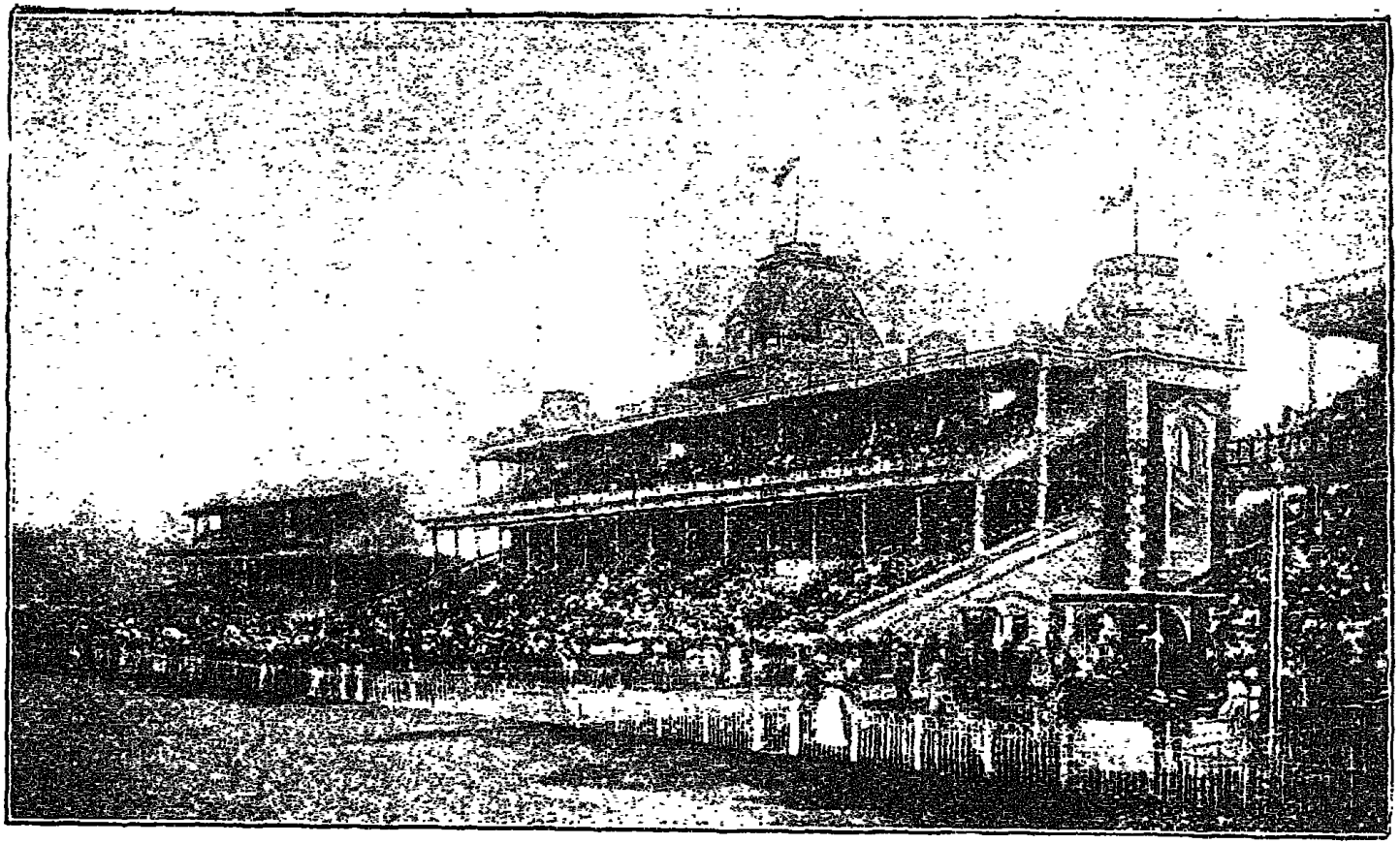
The Prinsep's Ghat is a commodious structure with handsome Ionic pillars near [illegible] of Strand Road. The river once [illegible] the pair of Peris seen on either side, guarded the top of a magnificent flight of steps running up from the river. This Ghat superseded Chandpal Ghat as a state landing stage. King Edward the VII landed here when he visited Calcutta in 1875 as the Prince of Wales. The present King-Emperor also landed here in state both on the occasion of his visit as Prince of Wales in 1906 and as King-Emperor in 1912. The ill-fated Emperor Nicholas of Russia when he visited Calcutta as Czarevitch in January 1891 also landed here. [illegible] whom the Ghat is named, was [illegible] of the Calcutta Mint and the founder of the science of Indian Numismatics. He died at the comparatively early age of 40 and this Ghat was erected by the citizens of Calcutta to perpetuate his memory.

About a quarter of a mile south of Prinsep's Ghat is the *Lascars' War Memorial*. A fine tribute to the devotion and valour of the seamen from Bengal who lost their lives during the Great War. Sir John Cumming, K.C.I.E., the member in charge of the Commerce and Marine Department of the Government of Bengal, took a personal interest in organising this beautiful memorial and it has given much satisfaction to the sea-faring community, most of whom are Muslims.

The Maidan.

The Maidan is a distinctive feature of Calcutta and is an open space of about two miles long and three-fourths of a mile in breadth at the north where it is narrowest, to about 1½ miles broad at its southern and widest end. It lies in the bosom of the city surrounding the fort (*killa*) as if it were in the hollow centre of a crescent. The river Hooghly forms its western boundary and the famous Chowringhee Road skirts its eastern extremity. From the Curzon Gardens in Esplanade East one can drive *viâ* the Red Road, the Casuarina Avenue and the Hospital Road right through the centre of the Maidan up to the gates of the Presidency General Hospital. There are other handsome avenues across the Maidan and the green wide expanse itself is studded over with [illegible] trees and tanks which keep the [illegible]. A drive through this green open space is most pleasing to the eye and soothing to the mind. Colonel Henry Watson, the Engineer of Bengal, laid out most of the roads including the beautiful Red Road and the Secretary's Walk alongside of it. Old Court House Street and the Esplanade were also built by him. He is remembered as the Engineer who supervised the final stages of the construction of Fort William and for having acted as the second of Francis in his duel with Warren Hastings.

The Maidan is largely used as a recreation ground. The principal Football, Tennis and Cricket Clubs of Calcutta have been allotted temporary sites by the military authorities. There are Golf Links, one for ladies and another for gentlemen, belonging to the Royal Calcutta Golf Club and also a Bowling Green. The Maidan is also dotted over with the statues of Viceroys, Commanders-in-Chief and other notables. The statues of Lord Curzon, Lord Kitchener and Lord Ripon are conspicuous additions of recent years. The *Calcutta Cenotaph* in memory



THE GRAND STAND, RACE COURSE (CALCUTTA MAIDAN).

of " the glorious dead " who fell during the Great War is also a new addition and is placed at the head of the Red Road, south-east of Lawrence statue facing Ochterlony Monument and the Curzon Gardens.

I cannot do better than quote at length the following glowing description from the powerful pen of Mr. H. E. A. Cotton in his " Calcutta Old and New " :

" Calcutta is proud of her statues and her monuments. Whatever may be the faults imputed to her inhabitants by critics, it cannot, at any rate, be laid to their charge that they have neglected to do honour to those whom honour is due. There is probably no city in the Empire so [illegible] adorned with statues of public men [illegible] by subscription. Outram, the Bayard of the East ; Mayo, struck down in the midst of a beneficent and patriotic career; Hardinge, the hero of Aliwara and victor of Moodkee, Ferozeshuhur, and Sobraon; Bentinck, the wise, upright and paternal administrator; William Peel, the Jack Tar of the Sepoy Mutiny; ' Clemency ' Canning; Napier of Magdala; Roberts of Kandahar and Pretoria; Duff [illegible] and Mackintosh; John Lawrence, [illegible] to be Viceroy [illegible] is for [illegible] wide expanse of Calcutta's historic Maidan. Others again there are whose effigies in marble and bronze do not greet our eye as we dash past of an evening in our victorias and our buggies. Warren Hastings, the first Governor-General of Bengal, and Cornwallis, the author of the Permanent Settlement and conqueror of Tippu Sultan, stand within the precincts of the Town Hall. Chantrey's masterly statue of [illegible] adorns the portico of the [illegible], and hard by is the marble presentment of James Wilson, the Finance Minister, who died while doing his duty. A brave list in truth and yet surely not without its notable omissions.

There is more than one maker of history for whom we seem to look in vain. [illegible] of men, is no longer enshrined [illegible] House which owes its existence to him and which is so apt a symbol of the empire he created. The Marquis of Dalhousie, the greatest of modern Governors-General, as Lord Curzon has fitly characterised him, now occupies no place of honour in the Institute which bears his name. Calcutta, nevertheless, has not forgotten them. In the course of a few years, these memorials of the illustrious dead will find a fit resting place in the Victoria Memorial Hall, the 'Twentieth Century Taj,' which will rear its graceful head upon the spot made hideous by the Presidency Jail. For t[illegible] sought in their temporary [illegible] unworthy of them. For they stand upon either side of the young Queen whom the one [illegible] to serve and the other lived to greet, while [illegible] them are the effigies of Neill and Havelock and Nicholson and Outram, and heroes of peace such as Rennell and Metcalfe."

Ochterlony Monument.

This is a masonry column situated at the north end of the Maidan, south of Curzon Gardens, at the Esplanade, and is provided with a flight of winding steps inside. It is 165 feet high and is covered by a cupola of Saracenic style. It was built in 1823 in honour of Sir David Ochterlony who brought the Nepal War of 1814—1816 to a successful termination. From the top of this Monument a beautiful view of Calcutta can be obtained. The public are allowed to visit it and can obtain the keys from the Police Headquarters at 18, Lall Bazar.

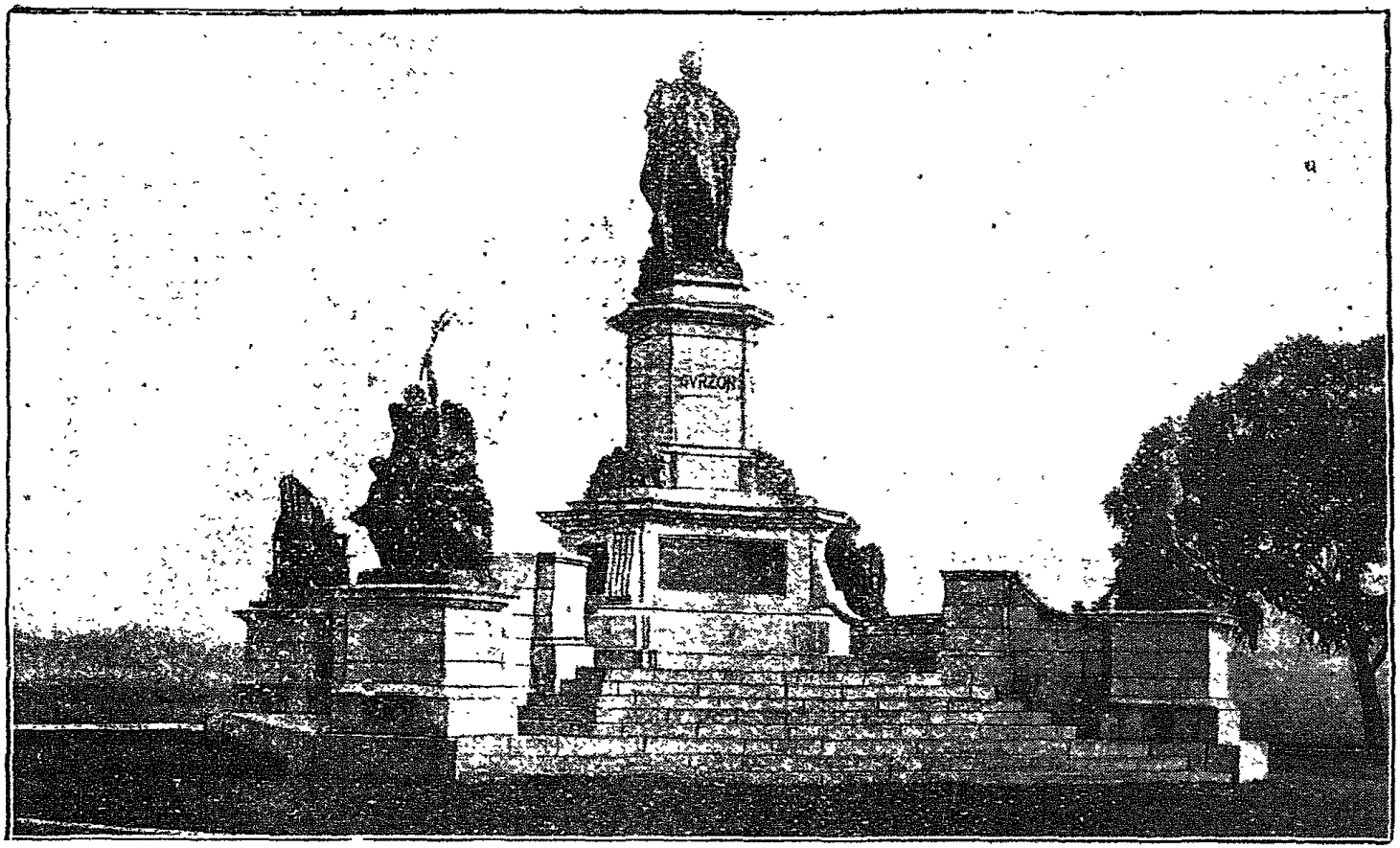
General Ochterlony is popularly known in Delhi as Akhterloney Sahib. He married a Muhammadan woman of the *Moghlani* class who is known as "Akhterloney Sahib ki Begum" as she got the status of a lady of rank being a General's wife. In mahalla

Hauz Kazi, near the police-station of that name in Delhi, is a beautiful red stone mosque built by Akhter-lonee Begum. It is said no public congregation is held in this mosque as the orthodox Muslims raised the objection that as the marriage of the Muslim lady with her Christian husband was illegal, the [illegible] sband could not be [illegible] endowment. This apparently unreasonable attitude accounts for this beautiful mosque, situated in the heart of a Muslim locality, remaining deserted and unused. It is however kept in good repair from the income of its endowments.

Curzon Statue.

Facing the north or the main entrance of the Victoria Memorial Hall, but outside the compound and right in the middle of the spacious public road called "Queen's Way," is a stately bronze statue of Lord Curzon. He is seen dressed in the robes of a Peer, standing high upon a magnificent pedestal, which is decorated with embossed representations of different important events in his administration. On the large sheets of bronze let into the four sides of the pedestal can be seen the Delhi Durbar Assembly, a squad of the Imperial Cadet Corps, the Victoria Memorial Hall, and the Tajmahal of Agra, the last, doubtless, referring to his scheme of restoration of ancient monuments, while carved out of white stone are four gun carriages resting at the four corners on the top of the pedestal. On the guns are bunches of lotus lilies, the emblem of India, and of Saraswati, the goddess of learning, referring probably to the re-organising of university education and revival of oriental learning.

The p[illegible] the centre of a raised platform o[illegible] is ascended by a flight of eight st[illegible] corners of the platform are seen [illegible] representing Peace, Commerce, Famine Relief and Agriculture.



THE STATUE OF LORD CURZON, QUEEN'S WAY, CALCUTTA MAIDAN.

The great Viceroy is seen looking towards the superb memorial which he had planned and had long before seen in his mind's eye raising up its graceful head adorning the famous Maidan of the Premier City of the Indian Empire. Surrounded by the green expanse the white pile with its well proportioned dome appears so impressive from a distance, specially when seen with the beautiful daybreak or, the glamour of a setting sun in an oriental sky as a background, that often one is reminded of the words of the Persian poet :

چناں نادر افتادہ در روضۂ
کہ در لاجورد ی طبق بیضۂ

" So exquisite it appeared surrounded by an extensive garden, that it seemed as if a pure white egg has been placed on the azure-tray " (Sky).

Victoria Memorial.

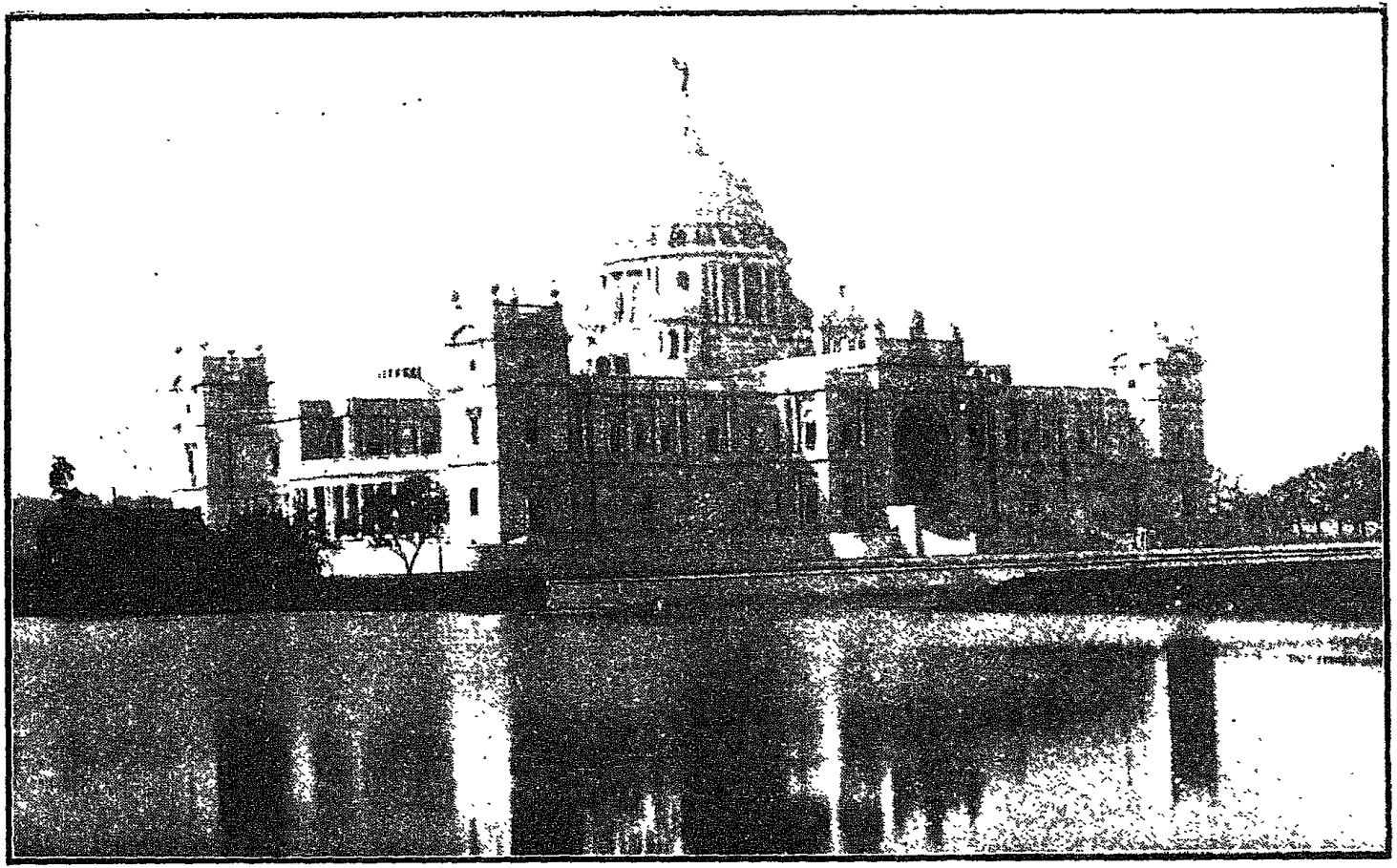
The idea of building this superb edifice in memory of the great Queen-Empress, was thought of by Lord Curzon in 1901. The palatial white building is surmounted by a lofty central dome, and has small kiosk-like turrets with graceful minarettes situated at the four corners. The building is situated in a beautiful garden interspersed with ornamental waters. This edifice is the *Taj Mahal* of the British. It is built in pure white marble. The design was completed by Sir William Emerson in 1903. Messrs. Martin & Co. of Calcutta are the builders. It took 15 years to complete. The estimated cost of sixty lakhs of rupees was raised entirely by public subscription. The building occupies the site of the old Presidency Jail noted as the prison where Raja Nanda Kumar was confined.*

* The house now occupied by the Free School in Free School Street was the residence of Mr. Justice Le Maistre who committed Nanda Kumar for trial on a charge of forgery and ordered him to be confined in the Presidency Jail.

The grounds and the surroundings are most tastefully laid out. The Victoria Memorial Collection has been housed in this building, and is a national museum of great historical interest. The foundation-stone was laid in 1906, when King George V visited India as Prince of Wales. His Majesty inspected the progress of the building operations during his visit to Calcutta in 1912. The Victoria Memorial Hall was opened in State by H. R. H. the present Prince of Wales in January 1922. The main entrance is to the north. Inside the garden immediately in front of the steps leading to the north entrance and facing Queen's Way is a majestic bronze statue of Queen Victoria, seated on a throne. The south gate has a lofty white marble arch surmounted by a fine equestrian statue of the late King Edward VII in a Field-Marshal's uniform. It was unveiled by H. R. H. The Duke of Connaught, in [illegible] the south entrance of the on[illegible]. Within the garden and just in front of the steps of the south entrance of the building is a handsome statue of Lord Curzon, in spotless white marble. The three sides of the carved marble pedestal of the statue illustrate some important event of his administration. In front he is shown receiving the chieftains of the North-Western Frontier Provinces who are paying their allegiance to the British Crown. On the east face he is inspecting the work of restoration of ancient monuments; on the west he is shown encouraging the promotion and development of indigenous industries and extending railway communications. The open grounds south of the Memorial buildings will be remembered as having been used as an Aerodrome for the Italian aeroplanes during the famous Rome to Tokio flight in the spring of 1929.

Race Course.

The Race Course in Calcutta is a famous institution and is about two miles long. It lies to



VICTORIA MEMORIAL.

the west of the Victoria Memorial building at the south end of the Maidan. The racing season begins in November and continues till the middle of March. There is also a monsoon meeting. The Christmas week is a great attraction. The Viceroy's Cup, which is run during this meeting, is a great society event. Betting is brisk and heavy. The Royal Calcutta Turf Club was established in 1861. Opposite the Race Course is the Station Hospital for British troops.

CHAPTER VI.

Dalhousie Square and Other Places of Historic Interest Near It.

Dalhousie Square.

This is the most important part of Calcutta, with all the Government and commercial offices round it. It has also the greatest historical association for the British. Its old name was "the tank square in the middle of the city" and an older name "the Green before the Fort." It was a place of recreation for the Company's factors who amused themselves on the banks of the fish-pond situated in the middle of the square. "It was dug," says the Dutch Admiral Stavorinus who visited the Settlement in 1770, "in order to provide the inhabitants of Calcutta with water, which is very sweet and pleasant." It has always been reputed to possess the sweetest water in Calcutta and until the introduction of filtered water-supply, was the chief source of drinking water for the European community.

The old Fort William and the Factory House of the East India Company occupied the whole of the western side of the Square.

Dalhousie Square is named after Lord Dalhousie who was Governor-General of India just before the outbreak of the Sepoy Mutiny. It is one of the prettiest open spaces in the city. The green lawn is interspersed with well-laid-out flower beds with

fountains playing at each corner. The turf on the slopes round the tank gently sweeps down to the edge of the sparkling lake the level of which is always kept high, by means of feeder pipes from the river. The Square was renovated and improved by Lord Curzon.

At the north entrance of the Square is a fine [illegible] statue of Sir John Woodburn, who died [illegible]: on the north-west corner is the white marble statue in a seated posture of Sir Ashley Eden. At the north-east corner is the statue of Sir Stewart Bayley; on the east side is that of Sir Andrew Fraser; all late Lieutenant Governors of Bengal. At the south-west [illegible] late Maharajah Sir Luchmissur Singh Bahadur, G.C.I.E., of Darbhanga.

Outside the Square enclosure on the east side in Old Court House Street is the memorial obelisk of Colesworthey Grant, the founder of the Calcutta Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals, in the year 1861.

General Post Office.

The General Post Office of Calcutta is one of the most handsome buildings in the City. It stands on the west side of Dalhousie Square, and covers a part of the site of the old Fort William. This graceful domed building with its tall Corinthian pillars and semi-circular verandah and beautiful flight of steps is the work of the same architect who designed Government House, namely, Mr. Walter B. Granville, architect to the Government of India. It is one of the most conspicuous landmarks in Calcutta and has a large clock with three illuminated dials. The foundation-stone was laid in 1864, and it was opened to the public in the year 1868. The removal of the foundations of the old Fort William was very difficult and could only be effected by blasting operations as the Muhammadan masons

THE GENERAL POST OFFICE.

used very thin bricks laid with a composition of *Soorkhi* or brick dust, lime, molasses, hemp and a mixture of animal and vegetable substances which, when set, became harder than was called the *Pucca* or *Rekhta Work*, and never needed the care of a P. W. Department.

At the north-east corner of the compound of the General Post Office is the site of the *Black Hole*. The following inscriptions on tablets on the walls

Rekhta Work, and never needed the periodical care of a P. W. Department.

"Behind the gateway immediately adjoining this spot is the site of the Black Hole prison in Old Fort William."

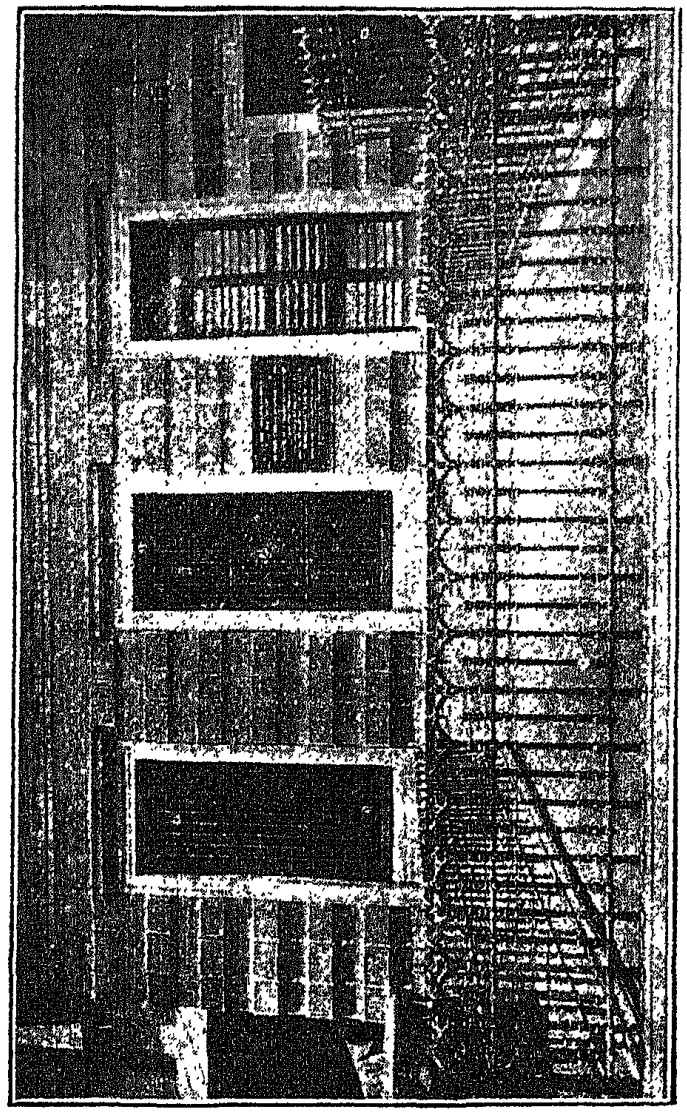
"The marble pavement below this spot was placed here by Lord Curzon, Viceroy and Governor-General of India in 1901, to mark the site of the pr known as the Black Hole in whic lcutta were confined on the nigh which only 23 came out alive. This pavement marks the exact breadth of the prison 14 feet 10 inches, but not its full length 18 feet, about the third of the area at the west end being covered by the building on wh this tablet is fixed."

Black Hole.

At the north-east corner of the General Post Office compound is a railed-off enclosure with a tablet indicating the actual site of the Black Hole of 1756. Lord Curzon got the place paved with black marble.

The Black Hole was the name of the small military prison of the Old Fort William. It measured about 18 feet by 14 feet at the floor and was about 18 feet high. Some say it was 18 feet square. It is said that on the night of the 20th June, 146 survivors of the garrison that defended Fort William against the Nawab of Bengal were confined in this dungeon. The horrors and sufferings of the victims crushed together and maddened with thirst and heat might be better imagined than described. The guards endeavoured to force some

water through the iron bars, but in the scramble that ensued many were trampled to death. When the doors were opened the next morning [illegible] only 23 who survived this agony and trial.



BLACK HOLE.

In fairness to Siraj-ud-Dowla it must be mentioned that he had simply ordered his officers to carefully guard the prisoners for the night and had retired to rest. He was not responsible for the details of the tragedy. Holwell is his " Narrative of the Experiences of the Black Hole " mentions that their incarceration in the Black Hole was " the

result or revenge and resentment in the breasts of the lower officers or Jemadars, to whose custody the prisoners were delivered, for the number of their order killed during the siege."

After a critical examination of facts, the Black Hole tragedy has been said to be a myth and literature on the subject has grown of recent years. One however feels inclined to believe that while the details are certainly open to grave doubts, and are most probably wrong, the story of the Black Hole cannot altogether be a myth as undoubtedly there was a military prison in the fort of that name which must have been naturally utilised to confine at least a certain number of prisoners, if not all of them.

There is no doubt that it is a physical impossibility to accommodate 146 persons of ordinary size in a space 18 feet by 15 feet even if they were laid one on top of another. That there was space for people to move about is certain, and is proved by Holwell's statement that "Mr. Edward Eyre, a Member of the Council, came staggering over the dead to him (Holwell) and asked him good-naturedly how he did and expired before he received the reply." "Holwell himself, determined to die apart from the struggle at the windows made his way back from the throng assisted by the strength of a ship's officer named Carey whose girl wife shared his prison and survived him after that night of horrors."

"Captain Mills (now Captain of the Company's Yacht) who was in possession of a seat by the window had the humanity to resign it, although life was equally dear to every man and the stench arising from the dead bodies was grown intolerable."

The above quotations not only show that there was sufficient room to allow one to walk to and from the windows, but the story of the stench arising from the bodies so soon after death shows an exaggeration which could only be believed by the English people

at " Home " who were not familiar with the actual rate of decomposition of the cadaver in the tropical heat of India.

Exaggeration of a feeling of resentment against an enemy is not an unnatural failing, especially when recruits and help are needed for warfare. It is a useful weapon to stir up the dormant feelings specially of those who have not been actually touched and feel no inclination to rouse themselves and avenge a wrong. The student of history has however to approach facts and sift them carefully with an unbiased mind and then try to arrive at conclusions.

In Lord Curzon's list thirty more names were added to those that Holwell originally recorded.

" This list includes not only the names of those who are known to have been killed or to have died in this room during the siege but also of those who either did not survive to enter the prison or afterwards succumbed to its effects."

Similarly Holwell's original list is also very likely to include the dead from all sources.

From an analysis of all these facts it appears very probable that amongst the dead thrown into the ditch of the ravelin on June 21st 1756, were included not only the bodies of those who died within the Black Hole prison but also of those who were found dead in other parts of the fort and the barracks. Indeed from the evidence before us it seems unlikely that the incident as handed down to us for the purpose of rousing our historical ire could ever have taken place.

Holwell Monument.

At the north-western corner of Dalhousie Square, at the junction of Charnock Place and Clive Street, stands the " Holwell " Memorial Obelisk. It is a white marble replica of the original brick and plaster monument erected over the grave of the victims of the Black Hole tragedy. John Zephania

Holwell, leader of the garrison that defended the fort after Roger Drake had disgracefully deserted it. and one of the few survivors of the tragedy, had built the original monument to mark the site of the ditch of the unfinished ravelin outside the eastern curtain of the fort into which the bodies of the victims were thrown on June 21st 1756. This fell into disrepair and is said to have been struck by lightning when the unsightly remains were removed in 1821 under the orders of the Marquis of Hastings.

It is said that the Governor-General thought that this monument was undesirable as likely to wound the feelings of Indians and Europeans alike, and recall the memories of a disaster of a controversial nature to no purpose. Looking at the inscriptions one would think that the removal of the obelisk was expedient.

The original inscription ran as follows :—

"This horrid act of violence was deservedly revenged on Siraj-ud-Dowla by His [illegible] under the conduct of Vice-Admiral Watson and Colonel Clive in 1757."

The words confirmed the tradition that horrible acts of retaliation and revenge were performed by Watson and Clive.

Lord Macaulay says :—

"This crime memorable for its singular atrocity, is memorable for the tremendous retribution by which it was followed.

Lord Curzon made material alterations in the original inscription of Holwell on the memorial obelisk put up by him. The bitter reference to the personal responsibility of Siraj-ud-Dowla was not in the opinion of Lord Curzon justified by the fuller knowledge of the facts.

For some time a lamp-post marked the place where the monument stood and then the statue of Sir Ashley Eden, Lieutenant-Governor of Bengal, was placed over the spot.

The statue was removed to Dalhousie Square by Lord Curzon who presented the city with the present obelisk which he placed over its original site. It was unveiled by him on 19th December 1902.

To the west of the obelisk, on the walls of the Calcutta Collectorate, is a tablet with the following inscription :—

" Sixteen feet behind this wall was the entrance of the east gate of Old Fort William through which the bodies of those who perished in the Black Hole were brought and thrown into the ditch of the Ravelin on the 21st June 1756."

Custom House.

The Custom House is situated between the Calcutta Collectorate in Charnock Place and the East Indian Railway House in Clive Street. It occupies portions of the Old Fort William within which the first Custom House found its habitation. The foundation of the present building was laid on the 9th February 1819 by Lord Hastings. The walls of the building bear marble tablets with inscriptions indicating the limits and position of the " Factory House " and other parts of the Fort. The pavement is marked with brass lines like those on the floor of the General Post Office and East Indian Railway House.

The tablets have the following inscriptions :—

" To the west of this tablet extended the range of buildings called the ' Long Row ' which contained the lodgings of Company's writers and divided the old Fort into two sections.

The brass lines in the stone on the adjacent ground mark the position and extent of the construction of the west curtain of Old Fort William near where it was met by the Long Row.

The brass lines in the stone on the adjacent ground mark the position and extent of a portion of the north wall of the Factory, the principal building in the centre of Old Fort William."

East Indian Railway House.

The East Indian Railway House is situated to the north of the Custom House. It provides

accommodation for the Agent's offices and also contains the offices of the Chief Engineer, the Chief Auditor, the General [illegible] the Controller of Stores, and the chief officers of the East Indian Railway Company and also the E. I. Ry. Press. The site occupies the northern limit of Fort William and the Water Gate. Brass lines in the courtyard indicate the position and a marble wall-tablet in the central quadrangle of the building has the following inscription :—

"The brass lines in the stone on the adjacent ground mark the position of the west curtain of Old Fort William.

"This tablet marks the position of the North River Gate through which Seraj-ud-Dowla entered the Fort on the evening of the 20th June 1756.

"Behind this tablet to the south of the gate stood the great flagstaff of the Fort."

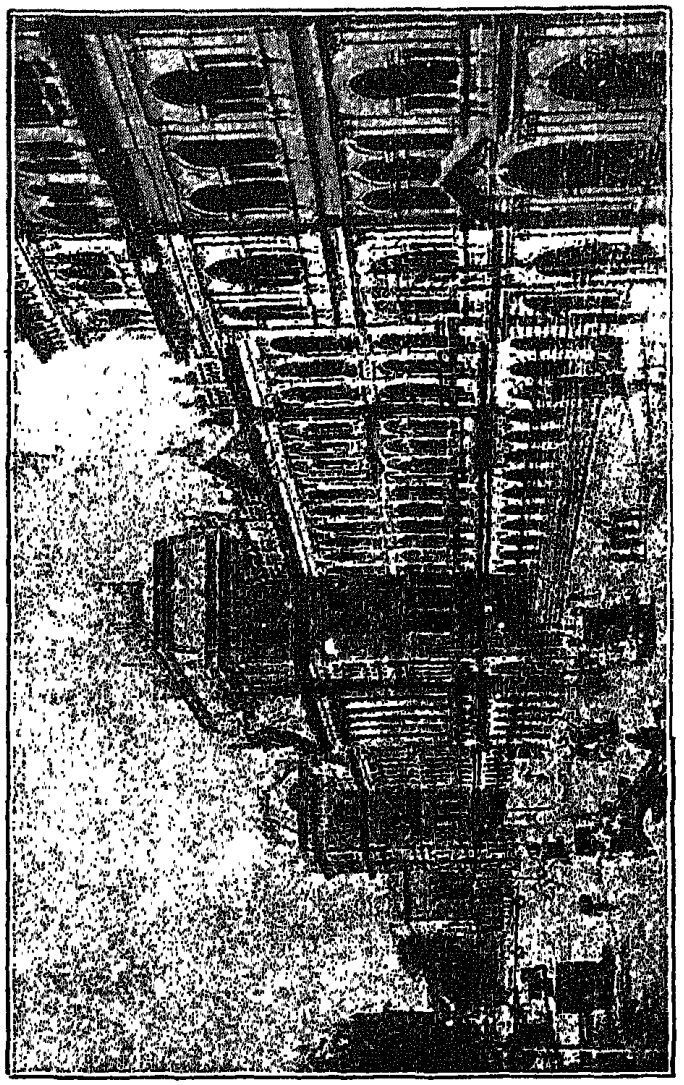
On the north wall of the building facing Fairlie Place is a tablet with the following inscription :—

"The [illegible] the position [illegible] of old Fort [illegible]

Writers' Buildings.

The Writers' Buildings is one of the oldest edifices in Calcutta. The offices of the Bengal Secretariat are located in this great three-storied pile of buildings. It fills the whole northern side of Dalhousie Square, from St. Andrew's Church to the Holwell Monument. The name "Writers' Buildings," popularly known as Company Barracks, is derived from the fact that the East Indian Company's junior employees, called "writers," were provided with free quarters in these buildings. There were 19 sets of such apartments which were allotted to those writers whose pay was less than Rs. 300 per month. In those days these young men lived a most careless life, and Writers' Buildings had acquired a fame for fast living and lavish orgies,

hardly to be beaten by any chummery of modern Commercial Calcutta. Subsequent to the withdrawal of the privilege of providing free quarters to the writers, these buildings were used as offices by merchants and private individuals, till Sir Ashley Eden, Lieutenant-Governor of Bengal, transferred



WRITERS' BUILDINGS.

the Bengal Secretariat to it. A handsome new frontage was built and extensive new blocks added at the back of the buildings towards Lyon's Range.

The frontage is adorned by a row of classical columns and above the façade over the central entrance is seen a statue of Britannia and the Royal

Arms; and from west to east there are allegorical figures of Science, Agriculture, Commerce and Justice. That portion of Writers' Buildings which up till 1908 contained the Bengal Legislative Council Chamber, is on the site which was once occupied by St. Anne's Church which got destroyed by fire during storming of the fort by Siraj-ud-Dowla's army.

I.C.S. War Memorial.

Occupying the south end of the corridor over the central porch of the Bengal Secretariat is a memorial obelisk of white marble with the names of the members of the Indian Civil Service from Bengal, who fell in action during the world-war 1914—18. The memorial has been put up by their comrades of the service in the province and was unveiled by H. E. Lord Ronaldshay in 1921.

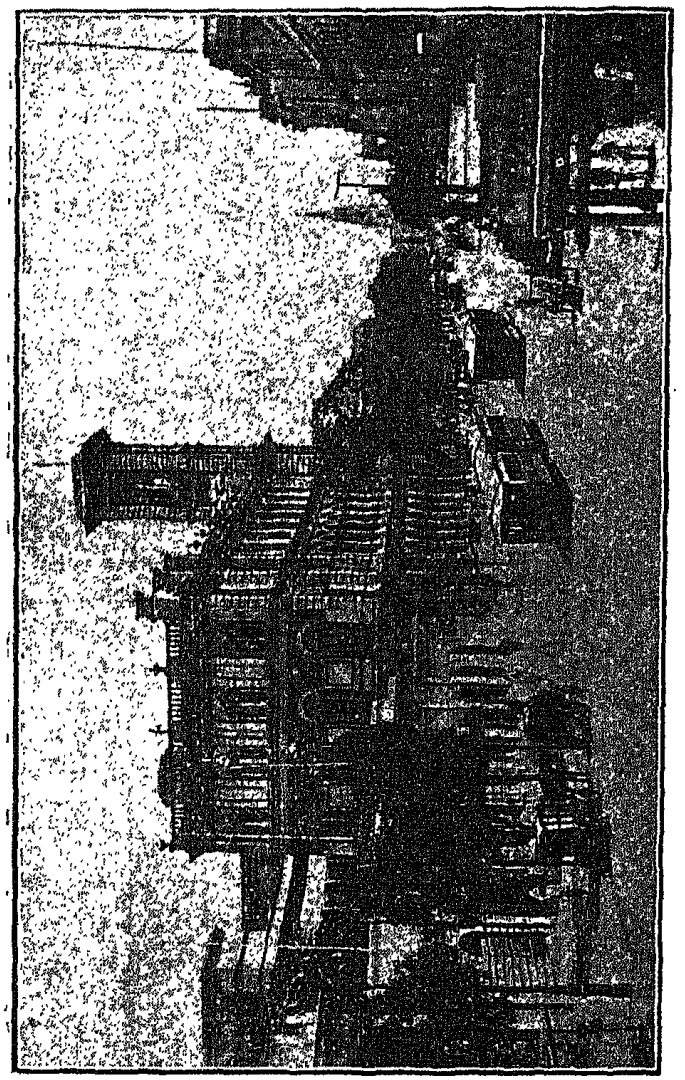
Dalhousie Institute.

This building occupies the centre of the south side of Dalhousie Square, exactly opposite Wellesley Place leading to the north gate of Government House. It was erected "as a monumental edifice to contain within its walls statues and busts of great men."

The Dalhousie Testimonial Fund and the funds raised to commemorate the heroic deeds of the distinguished men of the Mutiny in 1857, supplemented by public subscription to the extent of Rs. 30,000 were appropriated for its erection. The hall is available for lectures, concerts, dances and other entertainments. It also contains a library, reading-room and a billiard-room. The hall is of handsome design—90 feet by 45 feet—with a raised platform at one end. The walls are lined with marble with a semi-circular roof richly decorated. The Institute building was tacked on to the entrance portico which is much older and was erected in or about 1824. The foundation of the Institute was

laid on the 4th March 1855 with Masonic rights in the presence of Sir Cecil Beadon, the then Lieutenant-Governor of Bengal.

There is a fine statue of the Marquis of Hastings at the entrance portico, but a large number of busts and portraits have been removed to the Victoria Memorial Hall.



OLD COURT HOUSE STREET SHOWING CENTRAL TELEGRAPH OFFICE; ST. ANDREWS CHURCH AT A DISTANCE.

The Central Telegraph Office.

It is a conspicuous red building situated at the corner of Old Court House Street and Dalhousie Square South. The building stands upon a high plinth, about 4 feet 6 inches high, with three wings,